Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 3 · DAYS 29-63

The Abrahamic Covenant

Genesis 12-50

God chooses one man to bless all nations. Election, promise, and faith.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

Psalm 105 retells the covenant with Abraham. Psalms 121, 124, 125, and 37 teach trust. Psalms 47 and 66 look to the nations.

UNIT 3

In this unit

WEEK 5

29	Genesis 12:1-13:18	*Reading*
30	Genesis 14:1-24	*Reading*
31	Genesis 15:1-21	*Reading*
32	Genesis 15:1-21; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Hebrews 8:6-13	*Doctrine*
33	Psalm 105:1-22	*Psalm*
34	Genesis 16:1-17:27	*Reading*
35	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 6

36	Genesis 18:1-19:38	*Reading*
37	Genesis 20:1-21:34	*Reading*
38	Genesis 22:1-24	*Reading*
39	Psalm 105:23-45	*Psalm*
40	Genesis 23:1-24:67	*Reading*
41	Genesis 25:1-26:35	*Reading*
42	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 7

43	Genesis 27:1-28:22	*Reading*
44	Genesis 29:1-30:43	*Reading*
45	Psalm 121	*Psalm*
46	Psalm 124; Psalm 125	*Psalm*
47	Genesis 31:1-32:32	*Reading*
48	Genesis 33:1-35:29	*Reading*
49	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 8

50	Genesis 36:1-37:36	*Reading*

51	Genesis 38:1-39:23	*Reading*
52	Psalm 37:1-22	*Psalm*
53	Psalm 37:23-40	*Psalm*
54	Genesis 40:1-41:57	*Reading*
55	Genesis 42:1-43:34	*Reading*
56	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 9

57	Genesis 44:1-45:28	*Reading*
58	Genesis 46:1-47:31	*Reading*
59	Genesis 48:1-50:26	*Reading*
60	Psalm 47	*Psalm*
61	Psalm 66:1-7	*Psalm*
62	Review and Reflection	*Review*
63	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

DAY 29 · WEEK 5

Genesis 12:1-13:18

The call of Abram; the covenant promise; election and blessing

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 12:1-13:18 slowly. This is one of the most important moments in the Bible, the call of Abram, which sets in motion the entire story of redemption. Notice what God promises, what Abram does, and how Abram's faith is mingled with very real failure.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Unit 2 ended at the scattering of Babel and narrowed to one man, Abram. Today the story shifts decisively. From here forward, the Bible focuses on one family through whom God will bring blessing to all the families of the earth. This is the great narrowing that becomes the great expanding. Abram is called out of Ur, away from his land and kindred, to a place he does not know. The promise he receives is unconditional: God will make him a great nation, bless him, and bless all nations through him. Everything in the rest of the Bible, Israel, Christ, the church, flows from this call.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God's call comes with three commands ("go") and seven promises, land, nation, blessing, great name, blessing to others, cursing of enemies, blessing of all families.
2. Abram is 75 years old and childless when he is called. The promise of a great nation requires faith from the start.
3. Verse 4: "So Abram went, as the LORD had told him." Obedience is immediate, without discussion.
4. Abram builds altars at Shechem and Bethel, claiming the land for the LORD by worship before he possesses it.

5. Famine drives Abram to Egypt, where he lies about Sarai being his sister. The chosen patriarch fails morally almost immediately.
6. Pharaoh, not Abram, ends up rebuking him. God protects the promise even when Abram does not.
7. Genesis 13: Lot and Abram separate. Abram gives Lot first choice of land, generosity flowing from trust in God's promise.
8. After Lot leaves, God reiterates and expands the promise: "all the land that you see I will give to you and to your offspring forever."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 12 is where the story of redemption truly begins. The first eleven chapters of Genesis are sometimes called the prologue, creation, fall, flood, and Babel. From Genesis 12 onward, the Bible follows one family through whom God will reverse the curse of Babel and bring blessing to all the scattered nations.

Notice the structure of the call. God says three things to Abram: go from your country, go from your kindred, go from your father's house. Each command requires more sacrifice than the last. Country is general; kindred is closer; father's house is closest. God strips away every layer of identity Abram has built, geography, ethnicity, family, and asks him to find his identity in God alone. This is what every call of God involves at some level. Discipleship means letting God redefine who you are.

In exchange, God makes seven promises. He will make Abram a great nation, bless him, make his name great, make him a blessing, bless those who bless him, curse those who dishonor him, and bless all the families of the earth in him. Seven is the number of completeness. This is not a partial promise; it is a full, comprehensive commitment. And it is given to a 75-year-old man with a barren wife. From a human standpoint, every promise is impossible.

But Abram goes. Verse 4 is breathtaking in its brevity: "So Abram went, as the LORD had told him." No negotiation. No clarifying questions. He goes. This is what the New Testament will later call the obedience that comes from faith. Abram does not have full understanding. He has a promise from God, and that is enough.

Yet the chapter is honest about Abram's failure. As soon as famine strikes, he goes to Egypt, and there he lies about Sarai. He calls her his sister so that the Egyptians will not kill him to take her. The chosen patriarch protects himself by endangering his wife. God has just promised to bless him and curse those who curse him, and Abram does not trust the promise enough to tell the truth. The result is that Pharaoh rebukes Abram. The pagan king has more

integrity in this moment than the called patriarch. This is one of the Bible's repeated patterns: God's chosen people are real people with real failures, and the promise of God succeeds despite them, not because of them.

Then in chapter 13, after returning to Canaan, conflict arises between Abram's herdsmen and Lot's. Abram offers Lot first choice of land. Lot chooses the well-watered Jordan plain near Sodom. Abram is left with the hill country. But notice, after Lot leaves, God speaks again to Abram and expands the promise. "Lift up your eyes and look… for all the land that you see I will give to you and to your offspring forever." Abram lets go of his rights and God gives him more than he could have grasped for himself. This will be a pattern throughout the patriarchal narratives. Those who trust God do not need to defend their own interests; God defends them.

STEP 5

Connection

The scattering of Babel ended Unit 2 with humanity in pieces, alienated from God and from one another. Today's reading begins the answer. God will reunite the nations not by undoing the scattering but by working through one chosen family. The blessing promised to Abram in verse 3, "in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed", is the New Testament's gospel in seed form (Galatians 3:8). Every promise made to Abram is eventually fulfilled in Christ, who is the offspring through whom all nations are blessed.

STEP 6

Application

The call of Abram is the pattern for every Christian life. God calls. We go. We trust in promises we cannot fully see. We fail along the way, and God's promise stands anyway. Today, ask yourself: what is God asking you to leave behind? What identity, what comfort, what security has he asked you to release in order to find your life in him alone? And what promise has he given you that you are tempted not to trust? Faith is not the absence of fear or even of failure. It is going when God says go, building altars of worship along the way, and trusting that the same God who called you will keep his word.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God what "going" might look like for you, and what makes it hard to trust him with it.

Confess any time you have schemed to protect yourself instead of trusting his promise.

Ask him to make you a person who builds altars of worship wherever he leads.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

“In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.”

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 30 · WEEK 5

Genesis 14:1-24

Abram rescues Lot; Melchizedek, priest and king, bread and wine

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 14:1-24 slowly. This chapter contains a battle scene, a rescue, and one of the most theologically loaded encounters in the Old Testament: Abram's meeting with Melchizedek, a priest-king who blesses him with bread and wine. The chapter is short, but pay close attention, Hebrews 7 will treat this as a key Christological text.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday Abram and Lot separated. Lot chose the lush Jordan plain near Sodom, the region of cities we will hear about throughout the rest of Genesis. Today's chapter shows the danger of Lot's choice and the courage of Abram. Four kings from the east invade the area, defeat the kings of the cities of the plain, and carry off the spoils, including Lot. Abram, with only 318 trained men, pursues, defeats the invaders, and rescues Lot. On his return, he is met by two very different kings: the king of Sodom, who tries to negotiate with him, and Melchizedek, the mysterious king of Salem, who blesses him. The contrast between these two encounters is the heart of the chapter.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 13 calls Abram a "Hebrew" for the first time in Scripture, the term means "one who crosses over" and may relate to Abram's journey from Mesopotamia.
2. Abram has 318 trained men "born in his house." His household is large enough to constitute a small army.
3. He pursues the four kings as far as Dan in the north, over a hundred miles, and defeats them in a surprise night attack.

4. Melchizedek appears in only three verses (18-20), with no genealogy, no introduction, no follow-up, and never appears again in Genesis.
5. His name means “king of righteousness.” Salem (an early name for Jerusalem) means “peace.” He is king of righteousness and peace.
6. He brings out bread and wine, striking imagery that the New Testament will pick up.
7. Abram pays Melchizedek a tithe, a tenth of the spoils. This is the first tithe in the Bible, and it is paid to a priest greater than Abram.
8. The king of Sodom offers Abram the goods of victory. Abram refuses, swearing not to take “a thread or a sandal strap”, he will not be enriched by Sodom.
9. Abram’s refusal of Sodom’s wealth is paired with his receiving of Melchizedek’s blessing, accepting from God what he refuses from the world.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 14 is one of those chapters that seems simple on the surface but is theologically explosive once you see what it is doing. At the surface level, it is a story of military rescue. Underneath, it introduces one of the most important typological figures in all of Scripture: Melchizedek, the priest-king who prefigures Christ.

The military narrative is striking on its own. Abram, a peaceful nomadic patriarch, becomes a warrior to rescue his nephew. With 318 men, he pursues an alliance of four kings over a vast distance and defeats them. The text is not glorifying violence; it is showing that the man of faith is also a man of action when family is in danger. Faith does not produce passivity. It produces the kind of trust that enables courage.

But the heart of the chapter comes when Abram returns. Two kings meet him. The king of Sodom approaches with a transactional proposal: keep the goods, give me the people. The king of Salem approaches with bread, wine, and a blessing. The contrast is total. Sodom represents the world’s economy, favors traded, debts owed, transactions made. Melchizedek represents God’s economy, gifts given, blessings spoken, worship offered. Abram knows the difference. He refuses Sodom’s wealth and accepts Melchizedek’s blessing.

Who is Melchizedek? The text is remarkably restrained. He appears with no genealogy, no history, no future. He is king of Salem (later Jerusalem). He is priest of God Most High. He brings bread and wine. He blesses Abram. He receives a tithe. And then he vanishes from the narrative. The very absence of information is itself meaningful. He stands as a figure outside

the normal patterns of biblical genealogy, older than Abram (who pays him a tithe), greater than Abram (who receives his blessing), and unique in that he is both king and priest in a culture where those offices were rigidly separated.

The New Testament will pick this up with stunning force. Psalm 110 will declare of the coming Messiah: "You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek." And Hebrews 5-7 will spend three chapters showing that Jesus is the true Melchizedek, a priest-king greater than Aaron, greater than Abram, who offers bread and wine at the institution of the new covenant, who reigns over the true Salem, who blesses the children of Abram with all the spiritual blessings of God Most High. When Abram pays a tithe to Melchizedek, he is, in a sense, acknowledging the priority of Christ even before Christ comes. The whole Levitical priesthood that will later be established under Moses is foreshadowed and, in a sense, surpassed before it begins.

Abram's refusal of Sodom's wealth is the other side of the same coin. The man who has received from Melchizedek does not need to receive from Sodom. The believer who has received the blessing of God Most High does not need to be enriched by the world. The two transactions are mutually exclusive. You cannot worship at both altars. Abram chooses the higher one.

STEP 5

Connection

Abram's encounter with Melchizedek is one of the great Christological foreshadowings of the Old Testament. The priest-king of Salem, who brings out bread and wine and blesses the father of faith, points forward to the true priest-king Jesus, who instituted his new covenant with bread and wine and who blesses all the children of faith. Yesterday we saw the call of Abram, the beginning of God's promise to bless all nations. Today we see that the priest who blesses Abram already prefigures the priest through whom that blessing will ultimately come.

STEP 6

Application

Abram knew the difference between accepting blessing from God and being entangled with the world. Today, examine where you stand. From whom are you willing to receive? Are there "gifts" from the world, promotions, friendships, opportunities, recognition, that come with strings attached, that would compromise your loyalty to Christ? Abram knew that if he took Sodom's wealth, he could later be claimed by Sodom. The same is true today. Some offers must be refused, not because the things offered are inherently evil, but because their source would entangle you. Conversely, learn to receive from God. The Christian life is not earned; it is received. Receive your forgiveness. Receive your identity. Receive your daily

provisions. Receive the bread and the wine at the Lord's Supper, they come to you from your priest-king. And tithe, give back to God a portion of what he has given, as Abram did, recognizing the priority of the one who blesses you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Christ for being the priest and king who blesses you.

Ask God to help you refuse the gifts of Sodom and receive from him alone.

Tell him how you want to give back generously to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 31 · WEEK 5

Genesis 15:1-21

The covenant cut; God alone passes through, pure grace

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 15:1-21 slowly. This is one of the most important chapters in the Old Testament. The Abrahamic Covenant is formally cut here, and the way God cuts it is shocking. Pay especially close attention to verse 6, which the New Testament will quote repeatedly as the foundation of justification by faith.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abram has been called, has separated from Lot, has rescued Lot, and has refused Sodom's wealth. Now God comes to him again with reassurance. But Abram has been thinking. He is wealthy but childless. The promise of a great nation seems further away with each passing year. So in today's chapter, Abram does what he has not done before, he questions God. And God responds not with rebuke but with one of the most extraordinary covenant ceremonies in all of Scripture. This chapter contains the formal cutting of the Abrahamic Covenant, the seedbed of the gospel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God's opening words are striking: "Fear not, Abram, I am your shield; your reward shall be very great." God himself is Abram's shield and his reward.
2. Abram questions God for the first time: "O Lord GOD, what will you give me, for I continue childless?" Faith is allowed to ask honest questions.
3. God takes Abram outside, points him to the stars, and tells him his offspring will be that many. The promise is sealed under the night sky.
4. Verse 6 is the theological climax: "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness." Justification by faith is born here.

5. When Abram asks how he will possess the land, God responds with a covenant ceremony, animals cut in two, pieces arranged in two rows.
6. Abram falls into a deep sleep and great darkness, the same word used of Adam's sleep in Genesis 2. Covenants involve a kind of death.
7. God reveals the future: 400 years of slavery in a foreign land, followed by exodus "with great possessions." History is foreseen and ordered.
8. Then "a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between these pieces." God alone walks the path of the covenant, Abram does not.
9. The covenant is one-sided. God binds himself to fulfill the promise, regardless of Abram's faithfulness.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 15 is the chapter where the Abrahamic Covenant is formally cut, and the way God does it is one of the most remarkable scenes in the Bible. Once you understand what is happening, the gospel itself comes into focus.

The chapter begins with God reassuring Abram: "I am your shield; your reward shall be very great." This is enormous. God is not just giving Abram things; he is giving Abram himself. The shield is God. The reward is God. Every other promise, land, descendants, blessing, is secondary to this central reality. The greatest gift God gives his people is not what he gives them; it is himself.

But Abram is troubled. Time is passing and the promised son has not come. So Abram does something significant: he asks God a hard question. "What will you give me, for I continue childless?" This is faith being honest. Faith is not pretending that the promises feel fulfilled when they do not. Faith is bringing the unfulfilled promise back to the God who made it. Abram is not faithless here; he is faith-full in the most mature way. He takes God's promise seriously enough to ask about it.

God's response is to take Abram outside. Imagine the moment. The patriarch and the LORD, standing under the stars of the ancient Near East, a sky with no light pollution, blazing with millions of stars. "Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them. So shall your offspring be." It is a visual gospel. The promise is as vast as the cosmos.

And then comes verse 6, the single most important verse in the Old Testament for understanding the New Testament's doctrine of salvation. "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness." Notice three things. First, Abram believed. Faith, not works, is what God responds to. Second, God counted his faith as righteousness. The verb is

the language of bookkeeping. God moves something into Abram's account. Third, Abram did nothing to earn this. He simply believed the promise and was reckoned righteous. Romans 4 and Galatians 3 will use this verse as the foundational proof that justification has always been by faith, never by works of the law.

But the chapter is not done. Abram still wants assurance about the land. "How am I to know that I shall possess it?" God responds by establishing the covenant in the way covenants were sealed in the ancient Near East. Two parties seeking covenant would cut animals in half, arrange the pieces in two rows, and walk together between them, a vivid symbol meaning, "Let me become like these animals if I break this covenant." It was a self-curse oath.

Abram prepares the animals as God instructs. He waits. A deep sleep falls on him. God speaks the future: 400 years of slavery in Egypt, then deliverance, then return to the land. History is being scripted from this moment forward.

And then comes the most stunning detail in the chapter. As the sun sets, "a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between these pieces." The fire and the smoke represent God's presence, the same imagery that will later mark Mount Sinai and the Tabernacle. And God alone walks between the pieces. Abram, the human partner, sleeps. Only God passes through.

The meaning is overwhelming. In every other covenant ceremony of this kind, both parties walked through. Both parties bound themselves. Both said, "Let me become like these animals if I break my word." But here, only God walks. God binds himself unconditionally. Whatever happens to Abram or to Abram's descendants, the covenant rests on God alone. He alone is responsible for keeping it. And if anyone is to be torn like these animals to maintain the covenant, it will be God himself.

That is exactly what will happen. Centuries later, on a hill outside Jerusalem, God in human flesh will be torn, bearing the curse of the covenant his people have broken, so that the promise to bless all nations can stand. Abram saw it in shadow. We have seen it in light.

STEP 5

Connection

The first promise of redemption was given in Genesis 3:15, the offspring of the woman would crush the serpent. The line of promise has been preserved through Seth, Noah, Shem, and now Abram. Today the promise becomes covenant, formal, ceremonial, sealed in blood. Verse 6, "he believed the LORD, and it was counted to him as righteousness", is the heart of the gospel that Paul will preach in Romans 4 and Galatians 3. Abram is justified by faith, not by works. And the one-sided nature of the covenant points forward to Christ, who alone passes through the pieces, bearing the curse so that the blessing might come to all nations.

STEP 6

Application

Today, sit with verse 6 until it lands. You are justified by faith. Not by your performance. Not by your moral track record. Not by your religious effort. By faith, by believing the God who has promised, who has acted, who has sent his Son. Abram believed and was reckoned righteous. The same is true for you. If you have believed in Christ, his righteousness is counted to you, just as Abram's faith was counted to him. This is not a metaphor. It is the legal verdict of God over your life.

And sit with the one-sided covenant. God alone walked between the pieces because the covenant depends on him, not on you. If your faith feels weak, the covenant is still secure. If you fail, the covenant still stands. The God who bound himself to Abram has bound himself to you in Christ. Your security is not in the steadiness of your walking but in the faithfulness of his.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that your standing with him rests on his faithfulness and not yours.
- Confess any striving to earn what he has already given.
- Praise Christ who was torn so that you could be blessed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 32 · WEEK 5

Genesis 15:1-21; Jeremiah 31:31-34; Hebrews 8:6-13

Covenant Theology, A Framework

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 15:1-21 again, then Jeremiah 31:31-34 and Hebrews 8:6-13. These three passages span the Bible's covenantal arc: the Abrahamic covenant, the promise of the new covenant, and the New Testament's announcement that the new covenant has come in Christ. Read them with the question in mind: what is a covenant, and why is it the structure of God's relationship with his people?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you read the formal cutting of the Abrahamic Covenant, God alone walking between the pieces, binding himself to keep what he had promised. Today we pause to think more carefully about what covenants are and how they shape the entire Bible. Covenant is not a technical theological term invented by scholars. It is the Bible's own primary category for describing how God relates to his people. From Noah to Abraham to Moses to David to the new covenant in Christ, God always relates to his people through covenant. Understanding this category is essential for reading the Bible well.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 15 shows the basic pattern of a covenant: a sovereign initiates, makes promises, and seals them with an oath ceremony.
2. The Hebrew word berith ("covenant") first appears with Noah (Genesis 6:18), then runs through Abraham, Moses, David, and the prophets.
3. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promises a "new covenant" that will be different from the one God made when he brought Israel out of Egypt.

4. The new covenant features: law written on hearts, all knowing the LORD, sins forgiven and remembered no more.
5. Hebrews 8 explicitly identifies Christ as the mediator of this new covenant.
6. Christ's institution of the Lord's Supper uses the language of Jeremiah 31: "this is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20).
7. Every major covenant has a sign: rainbow (Noahic), circumcision (Abrahamic), Sabbath (Mosaic), throne (Davidic), the Lord's Supper (New).
8. The covenants build on one another, each new covenant fulfills what the previous covenants promised.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

A covenant, in the biblical sense, is a sworn relationship of personal commitment between God and his people. It is more than a contract, which is a transaction between equals for limited purposes. A covenant is a personal bond, sealed with promises and signs, that creates a relationship of mutual belonging. God says, in essence: I will be your God, and you will be my people.

The Bible's story is structured around a series of covenants. Each one builds on the others, fulfilling earlier promises while opening new dimensions. Understanding this structure is essential for reading Scripture well.

The first covenant in Scripture is the covenant with Noah (Genesis 9). It is universal, made with all humanity and all creation, and its purpose is preservation. God commits to maintain the natural order so that the larger story of redemption can unfold. The sign is the rainbow. This covenant is still in effect today.

The second is the covenant with Abraham (Genesis 12, 15, 17). It narrows from all humanity to one family, but with a promise that will eventually re-expand to bless all the families of the earth. Three things are promised: land, offspring, and universal blessing. The sign is circumcision. As you have just seen in Genesis 15, this covenant is unconditional, God alone walks between the pieces.

The third is the covenant with Moses at Sinai (Exodus 19-24). This is a covenant with the nation of Israel, organizing them as God's people under his law. Unlike the Abrahamic Covenant, this one has conditions, blessings for obedience, curses for disobedience. The sign is the Sabbath. The Mosaic Covenant does not replace the Abrahamic; it serves it, providing the structure by which Abraham's offspring would live as God's holy people in the land of promise.

The fourth is the covenant with David (2 Samuel 7). God promises David an everlasting throne. From his line will come a king whose kingdom will never end. The sign is the Davidic dynasty itself. This narrows further still, from a nation to a family within that nation, from a family to a king who will rule forever.

The fifth and final is the new covenant, promised in Jeremiah 31 and ratified in Christ. This is not merely another covenant; it is the fulfillment of all the others. Jeremiah describes it: God's law written on hearts (rather than tablets of stone), every member knowing the LORD personally (rather than learning from others), and sins forgiven definitively. The new covenant accomplishes what the Mosaic Covenant could not, it makes the relationship between God and his people internal, personal, and permanent.

Christians have debated for centuries how exactly the covenants relate to one another. Some traditions emphasize discontinuity, the new covenant is largely replacing the old. Other traditions emphasize continuity, the new covenant fulfills and extends the old. The framework this plan follows, sometimes called progressive covenantalism, sees the covenants as a unified, unfolding story. Each builds on the previous. Each is fulfilled in Christ. The Old Testament is not a different religion from the New Testament; it is the same story moving toward the same goal.

Several things follow from this. First, God always relates to his people through covenant. He does not deal with humanity merely as Creator or Lawgiver or Judge, but as covenant Lord, one who has bound himself to a people. Second, covenant is the structure of grace. Every covenant is initiated by God, not earned by humans. Even the conditional Mosaic Covenant comes only after God has already redeemed Israel from Egypt. Grace comes first; obligation responds. Third, the covenants are interconnected. The Abrahamic promise that all nations would be blessed finds its fulfillment in the new covenant, where Gentiles are grafted in. The Davidic promise of an everlasting king finds its fulfillment in Christ, whose throne is eternal. Fourth, Christ is the center. Every covenant points toward him. He is the offspring of Abraham (Galatians 3:16), the prophet greater than Moses (Hebrews 3:1-6), the Son of David, and the mediator of the new covenant.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The three passages you read together tell the covenantal story of the Bible in three frames. Genesis 15 shows the unconditional commitment of God to Abram. Jeremiah 31 promises a new covenant that will accomplish what the Mosaic Covenant could not. Hebrews 8 declares that Christ is the mediator of this new covenant.

Look at Jeremiah 31:31 carefully. “Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, not like the covenant that I made with their fathers on the day when I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, my covenant that they broke.” The Mosaic Covenant was broken. Despite all of God’s faithfulness, Israel could not be faithful in return. The law written on tablets of stone did not transform stone hearts. A new covenant was needed, one that would do something the old could not do.

And then Jeremiah lists the features of this new covenant. Three things stand out. First, the law will be written on hearts. The same God who etched the Ten Commandments on tablets at Sinai will now etch his law on the hearts of his people. Internal, not external. Second, all will know the LORD, from the least to the greatest. No more need for one Israelite to teach another to know the LORD; the relationship will be personal and universal. Third, sins will be forgiven and remembered no more. The sacrificial system of the Mosaic Covenant had to be repeated endlessly because the sins kept piling up. The new covenant deals with sin definitively.

Hebrews 8 then identifies the mediator of this new covenant: Christ. By his death, the new covenant has been ratified. By his Spirit, the law is being written on his people’s hearts. By his blood, sins are forgiven and remembered no more. The promise of Jeremiah 31 has been fulfilled. The covenant cut with Abram, sealed with God alone walking through the pieces, finds its ultimate fulfillment when Christ is torn on the cross, the divine party of the covenant bearing the curse so that the blessing of Abraham could come to all nations.

This is what it means to read the Bible covenantally. You do not see disconnected stories or random commandments. You see one God, one people, and one covenant promise unfolding in stages, each stage building on the last, all of them finding their yes in Christ (2 Corinthians 1:20).

STEP 5

Connection

Today’s doctrinal pause names what has been happening throughout your reading. God has been relating to his people through covenants from the beginning. Noah, Abraham, and the others you have read about are all participants in this single unfolding story. When you read the rest of the Old Testament, you will see Moses, David, and the prophets, each adding new dimensions to the covenantal story. And when you reach the New Testament, you will see Christ as the climax: the offspring of Abraham, the prophet like Moses, the Son of David, the mediator of the new covenant. The whole Bible is one story, and covenant is its spine.

STEP 6

Application

If you are a Christian, you are a covenant person. You are not relating to God merely as a generic worshiper or a religious seeker. You are bound to him by the new covenant in Christ's blood. Three implications follow.

First, your relationship with God is secure. Like Abram's covenant, the new covenant rests on God's commitment, not yours. The Father has bound himself to you in Christ. The Spirit has been given as the seal. You cannot break a covenant whose maintenance depends on God. Your assurance is grounded here.

Second, your relationship with God is communal. Covenants always create peoples, not just individuals. You are part of the church, the people of the new covenant. The Lord's Supper you share with other believers is the sign of this covenant. Do not try to live the Christian life alone. The covenant binds you to one another, not just to God.

Third, your relationship with God is transformational. The new covenant promised hearts changed, sins forgiven, and an intimate knowledge of the LORD. These are not future promises; they are present realities for everyone in Christ. The Spirit is writing God's law on your heart even now. Your sins are forgiven and remembered no more. You know the LORD, however dimly, because he has revealed himself to you. Live in light of this. You are not who you were. You are a new-covenant person, in Christ, by grace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he binds himself to his people by promise, and ask him to make that real to you.

Thank Jesus as the mediator of the new covenant.

Ask him to help you live out of that security, together with his people.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 33 · WEEK 5

Psalm 105:1-22

God's faithfulness to Abraham's covenant

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:1-22 slowly, twice. This is one of the Psalter's great historical psalms. It walks through the story of God's faithfulness to Abraham and his descendants. Read it as the appropriate response to the Abrahamic covenant story you have been encountering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 is one of the longest historical psalms in the Bible. It rehearses God's saving acts from Abraham to the conquest of Canaan. Today's reading covers the first 22 verses, from the covenant with Abraham through the early years of Joseph in Egypt. The psalm is essentially a hymn-form summary of Genesis 12-41 and a preparation for the Exodus to come. It teaches the people of God how to remember and how to give thanks.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with calls to give thanks, sing, and tell, worship as proclamation.
2. Verse 8 is the theological hinge: "He remembers his covenant forever, the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations."
3. Verses 9-10 specifically name the covenants with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the patriarchal line.
4. Verse 11 quotes God's promise: "To you I will give the land of Canaan as your portion for an inheritance."
5. The patriarchs are called "few in number, of little account, and sojourners in it." Their smallness is part of the wonder.

6. Verses 14-15: “He allowed no one to oppress them; he rebuked kings on their account, saying, ‘Touch not my anointed ones, do my prophets no harm.’” God protected them.

7. Then the psalm pivots to Joseph: “He sent a man ahead of them, Joseph, who was sold as a slave.” God’s sovereignty in suffering.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 105:1-22 is a worship-form summary of everything you have been reading in Genesis. It begins with the call to remember, to give thanks, to sing, to tell. And then it remembers, by rehearsing the story of God’s covenant faithfulness to Abraham and his offspring.

Verse 8 is the central claim. “He remembers his covenant forever, the word that he commanded, for a thousand generations.” This is the antidote to the despair that often accompanies covenant life. The patriarchs lived through famine, infertility, betrayal, slavery. They lived in a land that was not yet theirs. They saw children but not grandchildren of the promise. And yet, through all of it, God remembered. The Hebrew word for remember in Scripture is not passive recollection. It is active loyalty. When God “remembers” his covenant, he is acting in faithfulness to it. The psalm announces that this remembering is not just for one generation. It is for a thousand. Forever.

Verses 9-11 quote the Abrahamic promise directly. The covenant with Abraham was confirmed to Isaac and renewed with Jacob. It is a single, unfolding promise, the same God to the same family with the same word about the same land. And verse 11 puts in God’s own mouth: “To you I will give the land of Canaan as your portion for an inheritance.” This is what Abram believed in Genesis 15, and what God reckoned to him as righteousness.

Then the psalm becomes startlingly honest about the smallness of the patriarchs. “When they were few in number, of little account, and sojourners in it, wandering from nation to nation, from one kingdom to another people.” This is the truth about Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. They were not powerful. They were not numerous. They were nomads, vulnerable to every famine and every local king. And yet, the psalm says, “he allowed no one to oppress them; he rebuked kings on their account.” Pharaoh in Egypt, Abimelech in Gerar, God protected the patriarchs even from the most powerful men of their day. He still does this with his people. We are few. We are weak. We are sojourners. And he protects us.

The psalm then turns to Joseph. “He sent a man ahead of them, Joseph, who was sold as a slave.” This is the heart of the Joseph story before Joseph even reaches Pharaoh’s house. God sent Joseph. Joseph was sold by his brothers, betrayed, enslaved, imprisoned, but God sent him. The same God who promised Abram a great nation arranged for Joseph to be in Egypt so that the family could later be preserved through famine. What looked from the ground

like tragedy and injustice was, from heaven's perspective, sovereign provision. This is the doctrine of providence in narrative form. And we will see it played out in full when we read Joseph's story in the next two weeks of this plan.

STEP 5

Connection

The first chapters of Unit 3 have introduced the patriarchs, Abraham primarily, with Isaac and Jacob and Joseph yet to come in greater detail. Today's psalm teaches us how to receive these stories. They are not just family history. They are the record of God's covenant faithfulness, remembered for a thousand generations. As the unit unfolds, we will see the patriarchs at their best and at their worst. Psalm 105 reminds us that the story is ultimately about the God who remembered, not about the people who were remembered.

STEP 6

Application

Make remembering a habit. The Christian life is not primarily about discovering new truths but about remembering old ones, that you were lost, that you were redeemed, that you are loved, that you are kept. Today, recall one specific way God has been faithful to you in the past. Name it. Thank him for it. Tell someone about it. This is what the psalmist commands: give thanks, sing, tell the deeds of the LORD. Worship is, in large part, memory exercised.

And take comfort from the smallness of the patriarchs. They were few. You may feel few. They were of little account in the world's eyes. You may feel of little account. They were sojourners. So are you. And the same God who protected them protects you. He has not forgotten his covenant. He remembers, for a thousand generations.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for remembering his covenant, and for remembering you in Christ.

Tell him about a season that feels like famine or slavery, and ask him to preserve you through it.

Ask him to teach you to tell of his works.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

“In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.”

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 34 · WEEK 5

Genesis 16:1-17:27

Hagar and Ishmael; circumcision as covenant sign

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 43 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 16:1-17:27 carefully. These two chapters belong together: Genesis 16 shows Abram and Sarai trying to fulfill God's promise their own way through Hagar, and Genesis 17 shows God responding with renewed promise and the institution of circumcision as the sign of the covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It has been more than ten years since the promise. Abram is 86. Sarai is 76 and still childless. Faith and waiting wear on a person. Today's reading shows what happens when waiting becomes too painful, and what God does when his people take matters into their own hands. Genesis 16 is the Hagar story. Genesis 17 is God's reset: a renewed covenant, new names for Abram and Sarai, and the sign of circumcision marking every male in the household as belonging to the covenant.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Sarai's proposal, that Abram conceive a child through Hagar, was a culturally accepted practice in the ancient Near East, but it was outside God's promise.
2. Hagar conceives, and immediately the relationship sours. Hagar despises Sarai; Sarai blames Abram; Abram passes the buck back to Sarai.
3. God meets Hagar in the wilderness, the first appearance of "the angel of the LORD" in Scripture. He sees her and names her son Ishmael ("God hears").
4. Hagar names God: "You are a God of seeing." She is the only person in the Bible to give God a name.
5. Thirteen years pass between chapter 16 and chapter 17, silence between them.

6. God appears as “God Almighty” (El Shaddai), a name that emphasizes power adequate to the impossible.
7. Abram’s name is changed to Abraham (“father of many”). Sarai becomes Sarah. Names matter; identity is being reshaped.
8. Circumcision is instituted as the sign of the covenant, applied to every male in the household, including servants and the not-yet-born Isaac.
9. God repeats and intensifies the promise: nations will come from Abraham; kings will descend from him; the land is given as an everlasting possession.
10. When God promises Isaac will be born to Sarah, Abraham laughs. God names the coming son Isaac, which means “he laughs.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 16 and 17 belong together as a pair. They show what faith and unbelief look like when waiting on God’s promise. Genesis 16 is unbelief masquerading as practical wisdom. Genesis 17 is faith renewed by God himself.

The Hagar episode is a study in what happens when believers try to help God fulfill his promises through ungodly means. Sarai’s proposal was culturally normal in the ancient Near East. A barren wife could have a child through her servant, and the child would legally be considered hers. From a human standpoint, it was a reasonable plan. From God’s standpoint, it was a substitute. God had promised a child through Sarai. The child Sarai wanted through Hagar was not the promised child.

The consequences come quickly. Hagar conceives and despises her mistress. Sarai blames Abram for the situation she created. Abram refuses to lead and passes the problem back to Sarai. The household fractures. Hagar flees into the wilderness. This is what happens when believers try to manufacture God’s promises through their own ingenuity. The results are bitterness, blame, and broken relationships. God’s promises cannot be helped along by human strategy. They can only be received in faith.

But notice what God does for Hagar. He meets her in the wilderness. The angel of the LORD, almost certainly a pre-incarnate appearance of Christ, speaks to her by name. He hears her affliction. He gives her a promise about her son. Hagar’s response is one of the most remarkable confessions in the Bible: “You are a God of seeing… Truly here I have seen him who looks after me.” Hagar is the only person in Scripture who gives God a name. And the God she names is the God who sees the rejected, the abandoned, the wronged. This is who God is. Even in the middle of human failure, he meets the casualties with personal kindness.

Thirteen years of silence pass between chapters 16 and 17. Long silences are common in the patriarchal narratives. Faith must learn to wait. And then God appears again to Abram, this time as "God Almighty", El Shaddai. The name emphasizes God's power to do what nothing and no one else can do. It is the right name for this moment, because what God is about to promise is impossible.

The covenant is renewed with significant changes. Abram becomes Abraham, "father of a multitude." Sarai becomes Sarah, "princess." Names are not arbitrary in Scripture; they carry identity. By renaming them, God is reshaping who they are. They will live, from this point forward, as the people whose new identities reflect the promised future.

The sign of the covenant is introduced: circumcision. Every male in Abraham's household, including the servants, is to be circumcised. Why this sign? Several reasons. It marks the body, a permanent, irreversible sign of belonging to the covenant. It marks the organ of procreation, the means by which the promised line will continue. And it costs something, a literal cutting of the flesh that reminds the bearer that covenant entails cost. Paul will later argue that this sign was meant to anticipate the deeper cutting of the heart that the new covenant brings (Romans 2:29).

The chapter ends with Abraham laughing. God promises that Sarah will bear a son within the year, and Abraham falls on his face laughing, a complex laughter that is part joy, part disbelief, part wonder. God responds by naming the coming child Isaac, which means "he laughs." The first laughter in the Bible is the laughter of doubt; the next will be Sarah's laughter when she overhears the same promise. But God transforms their doubt-laughter into the name of the promised son. The God of grace turns even the patriarchs' unbelief into a memorial of his faithfulness.

STEP 5

Connection

The Abrahamic Covenant was cut in Genesis 15 with God alone walking through the pieces. Here in Genesis 17, it is renewed and given a sign, circumcision. Every Israelite from this point forward will bear in his body the mark of belonging to Abraham's covenant. The sign points forward to the deeper reality of the new covenant, where the heart itself is circumcised by the Spirit (Romans 2:29; Colossians 2:11). The Hagar episode also looks forward, Paul will use Hagar and Sarah as a contrast between the old covenant (children of slavery) and the new (children of promise) in Galatians 4.

STEP 6

Application

Wait. This is the lesson of these two chapters. When God makes a promise, the temptation is always to help him keep it through our own ingenuity. We propose Hagars. We construct alternatives. We persuade ourselves that we are being practical. And we wreck things in the process. Today, ask yourself: is there a promise of God that you have been trying to manufacture through worldly means? A relationship you are trying to force? An outcome you are trying to engineer? A future you are trying to secure on your own? Bring it back to God. Wait. The same God who waited until Sarah was ninety to send Isaac knows how to fulfill his promises in his time.

And take comfort from Hagar. God sees the casualties of human failure. He sees the wronged, the rejected, the abandoned. If you are one of them today, know that the God of Abraham is also the God who sees you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess where you have tried to help God keep his promises by your own schemes.
- Ask him to teach you to wait, and tell him what is hard about it.
- Thank him that he sees and hears those who are overlooked.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 5

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

DAY 35 · WEEK 5

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed introduced the man at the center of the rest of the Bible, Abraham. Take time today to let the sweep of his calling settle. The promise made to him is the promise that reaches you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"In you all the families of the earth shall be blessed."

GENESIS 12:3

REST

Meditation

Genesis 12:3 is the seed of the gospel in the Old Testament. Paul calls it the gospel preached to Abraham (Galatians 3:8). The promise made to one man is the promise that ultimately reaches every nation, every family, every reader.

Say the verse aloud, and notice what is and is not promised. It does not promise Abraham personal prosperity. It does not promise his descendants ease. It promises blessing, and blessing of a particular kind, blessing that flows outward. Abraham is blessed in order to be a blessing.

The same is true of you. If you are in Christ, you are a child of Abraham (Galatians 3:7). The blessing of Abraham, flowing through Christ, has reached you. And it has not reached you so that it stops with you. You have been blessed in order to be a blessing. Carry the verse this week with two questions: How has God blessed me through Abraham's offspring, Jesus? And to whom is he sending that blessing through me?

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week was the great narrowing. After Unit 2 ended with the scattering of Babel, God called one man, Abram, and through him began the redemption of all the nations he had just scattered. You read Abram's call in Genesis 12 and watched him obey, even with his failures. You met Melchizedek, the priest-king who prefigures Christ. You read the formal cutting of the Abrahamic Covenant in Genesis 15, with God alone walking between the pieces. You sat with the doctrinal pause on Covenant Theology, the structure that runs through the entire Bible. You worshiped with Psalm 105:1-22, which sings the patriarchal promise. And you read the Hagar story and the renewal of the covenant in Genesis 17.

The week's center of gravity is the covenant. God binds himself to one family so that, through that family, all families of the earth will be blessed.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where in your life have you been trying to fulfill God's promises through your own scheming? Sarai's proposal of Hagar was the practical, culturally accepted alternative to waiting. It produced bitterness, blame, and broken relationships. Where are you tempted to engineer what God has already promised to provide? What would it look like to wait instead?

What does it mean that you, a Gentile reader, are included in the promise of Genesis 12:3? In Galatians 3, Paul says that those who are of faith are children of Abraham, that the blessing promised to all nations has come to you through Christ. Sit with this. You are part of the answer to Abraham's calling. How does that reshape your sense of identity, your sense of mission, your sense of belonging?

How did the doctrinal pause on Covenant Theology this week clarify your reading of the Bible? Covenant is the structure through which God relates to his people from Noah to Christ. What is one specific way this framework has begun to change how you understand the Bible as one unified story?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that you are a child of Abraham by faith, brought near by Christ.

Thank Christ for keeping the covenant that you could not.

Ask him to make you a blessing to someone this coming week.

DAY 36 · WEEK 6

Genesis 18:1-19:38

The visitors; Abraham intercedes; Sodom destroyed

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 18:1-19:38. These two chapters tell the linked stories of God's visit to Abraham and the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah. They belong together, the same God who promises blessing also brings judgment. Pay attention to Abraham's bold intercession, Lot's compromised life, and the contrasting endings of the two families.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abraham has been circumcised. The covenant has been renewed. Now three visitors arrive at Abraham's tent in the heat of the day. One of them is the LORD himself. The visit will accomplish two things: confirm the imminent birth of Isaac, and reveal the coming judgment on Sodom. Today's reading shows the close relationship between promise and judgment in the life of God's people. The same God who blesses also judges. And in the middle of it all, Lot, Abraham's compromised nephew, is rescued from the burning cities, barely.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham shows extravagant hospitality to the three visitors, washing their feet, preparing a feast, standing while they eat.
2. The LORD promises that Sarah will have a son "about this time next year." Sarah laughs from inside the tent.
3. Sarah's laughter is rebuked but not punished. God hears her, even when she denies laughing.
4. Verses 17-19 are striking: God deliberates whether to hide his plan from Abraham, then decides to reveal it.

5. Abraham's intercession for Sodom (verses 22-33) moves in stages: 50, 45, 40, 30, 20, 10. Each request is bolder, but each is granted.
6. God's openness to Abraham's prayer is remarkable. The patriarch genuinely shapes the conversation.
7. Genesis 19 opens with Lot sitting in the gate of Sodom, a place of civic leadership. He has become a Sodomite in residence.
8. The men of Sodom demand to abuse the visitors. Lot offers his daughters instead, a horrifying response that shows how compromised he has become.
9. The angels strike the men with blindness and pull Lot back into the house. Even in his failure, God's grace pursues him.
10. Lot's wife looks back and becomes a pillar of salt. Lot's daughters get him drunk and conceive, Moab and Ammon, future enemies of Israel.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 18 and 19 are one of the most stark contrasts in the Old Testament. The two chapters happen at the same time but in different places. In one, the LORD eats a meal with Abraham, promises a son, and listens to bold intercession. In the other, fire falls from heaven and ancient cities are destroyed. The same God acts in both. The difference is not in God; it is in the relationship those two households have with him.

The visit to Abraham is extraordinary. Three strangers arrive at his tent, and Abraham extravagantly serves them. Only as the meal unfolds does it become clear that one of them is the LORD himself, perhaps a pre-incarnate appearance of Christ, accompanied by two angels. The same LORD who promised Abraham a son is now sitting under his tree, eating his food, and confirming the timeline.

But the visit is also for another purpose. The LORD says, "Shall I hide from Abraham what I am about to do?" And he reveals the coming judgment on Sodom. This is what it means to be a friend of God, and Abraham is called the friend of God multiple times in Scripture. Friends are told things. Servants are given orders. Friends are admitted into the deliberations of their friend's heart. Abraham is being told the future not so he can run for cover but so he can intercede.

And intercede he does. The negotiation between Abraham and God is one of the most remarkable passages in the Bible. Abraham works his way down, what if there are 50 righteous? 45? 40? 30? 20? 10? Each time, God agrees. Each time, Abraham draws nearer. This

is not Abraham manipulating God. This is God inviting Abraham into a conversation about justice. The patriarch is being trained to think and feel as God does, caring about the righteous, longing for mercy, willing to plead for cities he does not even live in.

Then the scene shifts. Genesis 19 opens with Lot. He has come a long way from when he and Abram first separated. Lot is now sitting in the gate of Sodom, the place where civic leaders gather. He has become a man of standing in a wicked city. His compromise is total. When the angels arrive, the men of Sodom surround the house demanding to abuse them. Lot's response is horrifying: he offers his own daughters to be raped instead. This is what years of living in Sodom have done to him. His moral center has so eroded that he is willing to sacrifice his daughters to maintain the cultural code of hospitality.

The angels rescue Lot anyway. They strike the attackers with blindness, drag Lot back into the house, and the next morning practically force him out of the city. "The LORD being merciful to him." Lot is saved not because of his faithfulness but because of God's mercy and Abraham's prayer. This is one of the clearest pictures in the Old Testament of grace operating despite human failure.

The endings of the two stories are painfully different. Abraham's tent ends in joy, laughter, food, promise, intercession. Lot's home ends in flame, salt, drunkenness, and incest. The two daughters, having lost everything, get their father drunk and conceive children. The two children, Moab and Ammon, will become nations that war against Israel for centuries. Lot's compromise produces a legacy of enemies. Abraham's faithfulness produces a legacy of promise.

The lesson is clear and sobering. Where you choose to live matters. The company you keep matters. The cities of Sodom looked attractive to Lot when he first chose them; they cost him everything in the end. Abraham, who chose the harder hill country, was the one with whom the LORD shared his meals and his plans.

STEP 5

Connection

The Abrahamic Covenant included the promise that God would "curse those who dishonor" Abraham. Today we see the inverse: God reveals his plans to Abraham as his friend, and rescues Abraham's compromised nephew because of him. The intercession Abraham offers prefigures Christ's intercession for his people, bold, persistent, asking for mercy on the basis of God's character. And the destruction of Sodom prefigures the final judgment, which Jesus himself will compare to the days of Lot (Luke 17:28-32).

STEP 6

Application

Two warnings and one comfort.

First warning: be careful where you settle. Lot did not become wicked overnight. He drifted, decision by decision, into a city that ultimately consumed him. The places you choose to live, the people you choose to befriend, the environments you choose to immerse yourself in, these shape you over time. Do not assume you will be unaffected.

Second warning: take Christ's words seriously. Jesus said, "Remember Lot's wife" (Luke 17:32). She turned back. She had been told not to. And her brief, longing look backward froze her in place forever. Do not look back at what God is rescuing you out of. Move forward.

The comfort: Abraham interceded for Sodom, and Lot was rescued. Christ intercedes for his people, and we are rescued. If you know someone today who is compromised, who is sitting in the gate of Sodom, who is drifting away from God, pray for them. Stand before God on their behalf. Abraham's intercession was not wasted, and yours will not be either.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to make you a friend he can trust with his purposes.

Pray for someone you love who is drifting toward compromise, in the way Abraham pleaded for Lot.

Confess any drift of your own, and ask him to turn you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 37 · WEEK 6

Genesis 20:1-21:34

Abimelech; Isaac born, the promised son arrives

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 54 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 20:1-21:34. These chapters cover Abraham's second deception (he again calls Sarah his sister) and the long-awaited birth of Isaac. Notice how God protects Abraham even when Abraham fails, and how the promise finally arrives after twenty-five years of waiting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It has been twenty-five years since Abraham was first called. He has aged. Sarah has aged. The promise of a son has lived in his household longer than many marriages last. Today's reading is the climax of the long wait. But it begins with another shameful episode, Abraham again lying about Sarah being his sister, this time to Abimelech of Gerar. The text candidly shows that the chosen patriarch has not learned from his earlier mistake. And yet, in the middle of his failure, the promise finally arrives. Isaac is born.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham repeats the sin of Genesis 12, telling Abimelech that Sarah is his sister.
2. Abimelech, the pagan king, has more integrity than Abraham. God protects Sarah by appearing to Abimelech in a dream.
3. Verse 7 calls Abraham a "prophet", the first occurrence of the word in Scripture, applied to the man who has just lied.
4. Abraham prays for Abimelech's household and they are healed. God uses imperfect prophets.
5. Isaac is born in 21:2: "The LORD did to Sarah as he had promised." Twenty-five years of waiting is summed up in one verse.

6. Isaac's name means "he laughs." Sarah says, "God has made laughter for me; everyone who hears will laugh over me."
7. Tensions flare again between Sarah and Hagar. Sarah demands Hagar and Ishmael be cast out. God tells Abraham to do as Sarah says.
8. God meets Hagar in the wilderness a second time. He hears the boy's voice and provides water.
9. The chapter ends with Abraham planting a tamarisk tree at Beersheba and calling on the name of the LORD, "the Everlasting God."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 20 and 21 belong together as a pair. The first chapter shows Abraham's continuing weakness; the second shows God's unfailing promise. The point is the same one the Bible has been making since Noah: God's covenant succeeds despite his people, not because of them.

Genesis 20 is one of those passages that makes Christians uncomfortable. Abraham, the great patriarch, lies again. He tells Abimelech of Gerar that Sarah is his sister, and Abimelech, believing him, takes her into his household. This is the second time Abraham has done this. He has not learned. The man whom we have come to admire for his faith is also a man who repeatedly tries to protect himself by endangering his wife.

But notice what God does. God comes to Abimelech in a dream and warns him. Abimelech, a pagan king, listens to God and protects Sarah. The text is making a point: God can protect the covenant even from the covenant-bearer's failures. The promise does not depend on Abraham's performance. It depends on God's faithfulness.

And then comes one of the most surprising verses in Genesis. God tells Abimelech, "He is a prophet, and he will pray for you, and you shall live." Abraham, who has just lied, is called a prophet. He is told to pray for the king he wronged. And God heals Abimelech's household. This is the strange and beautiful logic of grace. God uses imperfect people. He calls liars prophets. He turns failures into intercessors. If you have been waiting to be useful to God until you are no longer a sinner, you will wait forever. Abraham was useful to God while still sinning.

Genesis 21 then brings the long-awaited miracle. Verse 2: "Sarah conceived and bore Abraham a son in his old age at the time of which God had spoken to him." Twenty-five years compressed into a single sentence. The covenant has produced its first fruit. The promise has begun to be fulfilled in flesh and blood. Isaac is here.

His name, laughter, captures everything. Sarah laughed in Genesis 18 when she overheard the promise. She is laughing now in Genesis 21 because the promise has come true. "Everyone who hears will laugh over me." The God who keeps impossible promises is the God who produces joy in his people. The laughter of unbelief has been transformed into the laughter of fulfillment.

But the chapter also contains pain. Tensions with Hagar and Ishmael flare again. Sarah demands they be cast out. Abraham is grieved, Ishmael is his son too. But God tells Abraham to do as Sarah says, and God promises to take care of Hagar and Ishmael himself. He does. He meets Hagar in the wilderness a second time, hears the boy's cries, opens her eyes to see a well, and pledges to make Ishmael into a nation.

Paul will later use this episode allegorically in Galatians 4 to contrast the two covenants, Hagar representing slavery and law, Sarah representing freedom and promise. The point Paul draws out is already present in the narrative: the child of the slave woman cannot be the heir of the promise. The promise comes through the impossible son, miraculously given, freely received.

The chapter ends with Abraham planting a tamarisk tree at Beersheba and calling on the name of the LORD, El Olam, the Everlasting God. After twenty-five years of waiting, after laughter and tears, after lies and miracles, Abraham worships the God whose timeline is eternal and whose promises do not fail.

STEP 5

Connection

Twenty-five years ago in this plan's timeline, Abraham was called and given a promise. Today, the promise is fulfilled in Isaac. The faithfulness of God across that long wait is what the whole Bible is about. Isaac is the promised son, born by miracle to aged parents, and he points forward to the greater promised Son, born by miracle to a virgin, the true offspring of Abraham in whom all nations will be blessed. Sarah's laughter prefigures Mary's Magnificat. The God who made Sarah laugh is the God who makes his people sing.

STEP 6

Application

The promise comes, but it takes time. Today, take heart from twenty-five years. The God who fulfilled the promise to Abraham is the same God who has made promises to you. If you have been waiting for years for something, a healing, a reconciliation, a child, a calling, a deliverance, Abraham's story is your story too. God does not forget. He has not abandoned you. The timeline of fulfillment is not the timeline of impatience.

And take heart from the fact that Abraham, who lied repeatedly, was called a prophet and used by God to bring healing. Your failures do not disqualify you from being used by God. The covenant rests on him, not on you. Keep walking. Keep praying. Keep planting trees of worship in every place God brings you. The Everlasting God is faithful.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you are waiting for, and where waiting has tempted you to scheme.
- Thank him that his promises come in his time.
- Ask him to use you in the middle of your failures.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 38 · WEEK 6

Genesis 22:1-24

The binding of Isaac, substitution, faith, the mountain of the Lord

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 24 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 22:1-24 with great care. This is one of the most theologically loaded chapters in the entire Old Testament, the binding of Isaac. Hebrews 11, Romans 8, and the entire Gospel of John echo this passage. Read it slowly, as if you have never read it before.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaac is the promised son. He is the fulfillment of twenty-five years of waiting, the carrier of the covenant, the link between Abraham and the great nation that is to come. And today, God asks Abraham to kill him. This chapter is one of the most disturbing and one of the most glorious in the Bible. It tests Abraham's faith to its absolute limit. It reveals the depth of his trust in God. And it foreshadows, more clearly than almost any other Old Testament passage, the sacrifice that God himself will one day make.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1 frames the entire chapter: "After these things God tested Abraham." What follows is a test, not a divine cruelty.
2. God's command is excruciatingly specific: "Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love." Three layers of identity, son, only son, beloved.
3. Abraham rises "early in the morning", immediate obedience, the same phrase used in Genesis 19:27 when he prayed for Sodom.
4. The three-day journey to Moriah gave Abraham time to second-guess. He did not turn back.

5. Verse 5 contains a remarkable statement: “We will worship and come again to you.” Abraham expected to return WITH Isaac.
6. Verse 8: “God will provide for himself the lamb.” This becomes the chapter’s central theological claim.
7. Isaac, old enough to carry the wood, does not resist. He is a willing participant in his own near-sacrifice.
8. The angel of the LORD calls from heaven at the climactic moment. The knife is stopped mid-air.
9. A ram is caught in the thicket. Abraham offers the ram “instead of his son”, substitutionary sacrifice in pure form.
10. Abraham names the place “The LORD will provide” (Yahweh-yireh).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 22 is one of the most theologically dense chapters in the Bible. It tests Abraham’s faith, demonstrates the principle of substitutionary sacrifice, and foreshadows the death of Christ with such specificity that it is hard to read any other way once you see it.

The chapter opens with a sentence that frames everything. “After these things God tested Abraham.” This is a test. God is not changing his mind about the covenant. He is not reverting to child sacrifice. He is testing the depth of Abraham’s faith. Abraham does not know it is a test. We, the readers, are told. This is important. Abraham acts in faith without knowing the outcome. We watch knowing how the story ends. Both perspectives matter.

God’s command lands with maximum weight. “Take your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering.” Three terms of endearment piled on top of each other. The very son who was promised. The son for whom Abraham waited twenty-five years. The son in whom the covenant rests. Offer him. The Hebrew is clear: kill him and burn him.

Abraham’s response is the stuff of faith’s hall of fame. He gets up early the next morning. He saddles the donkey. He gathers wood. He takes Isaac and two servants. He goes. There is no argument, no negotiation, no delay. Hebrews 11 tells us what was going on in his heart: “He considered that God was able even to raise him from the dead, from which, figuratively speaking, he did receive him back.” Abraham reasoned this way: God promised that through Isaac my offspring would be reckoned. If I kill Isaac, God must raise him from the dead, because his promise cannot fail. This is faith at its zenith, trusting God’s faithfulness even more than the apparent meaning of his command.

The three-day journey is excruciating. Abraham had time to second-guess. He did not. When they arrived, he told the servants, "Stay here with the donkey; I and the boy will go over there and worship and come again to you." Notice: we will come again. Plural. Abraham expected to return with Isaac, one way or another. He did not know how, but he knew God.

The most haunting moment in the chapter is verse 7. Isaac, carrying the wood, asks his father: "Behold, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" Abraham's answer is one of the most beautiful sentences in the Old Testament: "God will provide for himself the lamb." It is both a comforting word to Isaac and a prophecy Abraham could not have fully understood. God will provide the lamb. Centuries later, John the Baptist will see Jesus walking toward him and say, "Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world." God did provide. He provided himself.

The climactic moment comes with the knife raised. The angel of the LORD calls from heaven. Abraham's hand is stayed. He sees a ram caught in a thicket. He sacrifices the ram "instead of his son." This is substitutionary atonement in its purest visual form. The son is spared because the ram dies in his place. Abraham names the place "The LORD will provide", Yahweh-yireh.

The chapter ends with a renewed and intensified promise. Because Abraham did not withhold his son, God will surely bless him, multiply his offspring as the stars and the sand, and through his offspring all the nations of the earth will be blessed. The blessing is now sealed by Abraham's tested obedience.

But the deepest layer of this chapter only becomes visible from the New Testament side. Abraham was asked to do what he was, in the end, not asked to complete. God himself, however, did not spare his only beloved Son. Romans 8:32 echoes Genesis 22 directly: "He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?" The same word, did not spare, appears in both. At Moriah, the son was spared. At Calvary, the Son was not. Because God provided for himself the Lamb.

STEP 5

Connection

The Abrahamic Covenant has been given, cut, signed, fulfilled in Isaac's birth, and now tested at the mountain of the LORD. The mountain is Moriah, the same region where the Temple will later be built, where centuries of sacrifices will be offered, and (according to Jewish tradition) very near where Christ will be crucified. The chapter is a foreshadowing of the Gospel itself. The beloved son carrying wood up the hill of the LORD. The substitute provided by God. The son spared because another died in his place. The blessing of all nations flowing from one obedient man. Every detail points forward to Calvary.

STEP 6

Application

What is your Isaac? It is a question every believer must eventually face. What has God given you that you would struggle to give back to him? It might be a relationship. A career. A child. A reputation. A dream. The God who tests his people will, sooner or later, ask you to hold whatever you love with an open hand. He may not require you to give it up. He often does not. But he requires you to be willing.

This is hard. It feels like cruelty when you first encounter it. But it is mercy. God knows that whatever you cannot release will eventually rule you. The thing you grip most tightly is the thing most likely to become your god. He asks you to release Isaac so that Isaac can be received back, but as gift, not as idol.

Today, name your Isaac. Bring it before God. Hold it loosely. And remember: the God who tested Abraham is the same God who did not spare his own Son. He has already given his most. Trust him with yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he did not spare his own Son for you.
- Ask him to show you what you are holding too tightly, and to help you open your hand.
- Praise Christ as the Lamb God provided.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 39 · WEEK 6

Psalm 105:23-45

From Joseph to the Exodus, God's faithfulness through adversity

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 23 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 105:23-45 slowly, twice. This is the second half of the historical psalm we began on Day 29. Today's section covers Joseph in Egypt through the Exodus, God's faithfulness across centuries and through hardship. It is the perfect bridge from the patriarchal stories to the next phase of God's covenant work.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 105 began with Abraham and the patriarchs. Today's portion picks up at Joseph's descent into Egypt and traces God's faithfulness through the years of slavery, the plagues, the Exodus, and the wilderness wanderings, all the way to the gift of the land. The psalm is a sweeping summary of the next several units in this plan. It rehearses what God has done so that the people of God will know how to give thanks.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 23: "Then Israel came to Egypt; Jacob sojourned in the land of Ham." The patriarchal family becomes a nation in exile.
2. Verse 24: "And the LORD made his people very fruitful and made them stronger than their foes." Multiplication in exile.
3. Verse 25 is striking: "He turned their hearts to hate his people." Even Egyptian hostility is under God's sovereignty.
4. Moses and Aaron are sent, chosen instruments for the deliverance to come.
5. Verses 27-36 summarize the ten plagues in poetic form. Each is an attack on Egypt's gods.

6. Verse 37: “Then he brought out Israel with silver and gold, and there was none among his tribes who stumbled.” Provision and protection.
7. Verses 39-41: The pillar of cloud, the manna, the water from the rock, wilderness providence.
8. Verse 42 is the theological refrain: “For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant.” Everything that happened was the fulfillment of the covenant.
9. The psalm ends with the gift of the land, “the lands of the nations”, and the call to praise the LORD.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 105:23-45 is the divine view of Israel’s long story. From the ground, the descent into Egypt looked like tragedy. The years of slavery looked like abandonment. The plagues and the Exodus looked like a contested struggle. From God’s perspective, every step was the fulfillment of his promise to Abraham. This is what historical psalms do. They take the grand sweep of redemptive history and show how every event served God’s covenantal purposes.

Verse 23 introduces Egypt by saying Jacob “sojourned in the land of Ham.” This is theologically loaded. Ham was Noah’s son, and the land of Ham represents the post-flood world outside the line of promise. Israel is now in that world, far from the land of promise, surrounded by foreign gods, growing in number among people who do not know the LORD.

But notice verse 24: “He made his people very fruitful and made them stronger than their foes.” This echoes Genesis 1:28, be fruitful and multiply. The dominion mandate is being fulfilled even in slavery. God’s people grow in number in the very land that will eventually try to crush them. This is one of the great patterns of biblical theology. God multiplies his people in the most hostile environments.

Verse 25 is one of the most theologically remarkable verses in the Psalter: “He turned their hearts to hate his people, to deal craftily with his servants.” Even Egyptian hostility was under God’s sovereign control. This does not mean God caused sin in the Egyptians’ hearts. It means he ordered history in such a way that their natural hostility served his redemptive purpose. The same Pharaoh who oppressed Israel becomes the means by which Israel is forged into a nation and then delivered with mighty signs. Romans 9 will appeal to this principle when Paul discusses God’s sovereignty over Pharaoh’s hardening.

The psalm then summarizes the plagues. What strikes the modern reader is how each plague is described as God’s action. He turned waters to blood. He sent flies. He gave them hail. He spoke and locusts came. The plagues are not natural disasters. They are direct interventions

of the covenant Lord against the gods of Egypt. Each plague targets a specific deity, Hapi the Nile god, Heqet the frog goddess, Ra the sun god, and so on. The plagues are theological warfare.

The Exodus itself is described as victory and provision. "Then he brought out Israel with silver and gold, and there was none among his tribes who stumbled." The people who entered Egypt as a small clan leave as a great nation, loaded with the wealth of their oppressors, none of them sick or weak. This is the God who keeps his promises.

And then verses 39-41 cover the wilderness. The cloud by day, the fire by night. Manna from heaven. Water from the rock. The providence of God in the desert. The psalmist is preparing us for the next two units of our reading, Exodus through Deuteronomy, and reminding us that this whole period was God's faithful provision.

Verse 42 is the hinge: "For he remembered his holy promise, and Abraham, his servant." Everything in the Exodus story flows from the Abrahamic Covenant. The plagues, the deliverance, the wilderness provision, the inheritance of the land, all of it is the fulfillment of what God promised Abraham four hundred years earlier. The covenants of God do not expire. They unfold.

The psalm closes with the gift of the land. God gave them the lands of the nations. They received the fruit of others' labor. Not because they deserved it, but because God had promised. And the only fitting response is praise. Hallelujah.

STEP 5

Connection

Today's psalm is a bridge. It looks back over what we have read, God's covenant with Abraham, his faithfulness through the patriarchs, his preservation in Egypt, and forward to what we will read next: the Exodus, the wilderness, and the entry into the land. Everything that happens in the next several units of this plan is the unfolding of the promise made to Abraham. The psalm helps us see the whole arc.

STEP 6

Application

Live in the awareness that every part of your story is part of God's larger story. The descent into difficult times may feel like loss, but God multiplied Israel in Egypt. The years of waiting may feel like abandonment, but God remembered his promise. The hostility you face may feel personal, but God has used the hostility of others to forge his people for generations. Whatever you are walking through today, ask the question Psalm 105 keeps asking: how is this serving God's larger purposes? You may not know in the moment. Israel did not know in the moment. But God remembered, and he is remembering still.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being faithful across long years of waiting and trouble.

Tell him about a season that feels like Egypt, and ask him to make you fruitful there.

Ask him to bring you into all he has promised.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 40 · WEEK 6

Genesis 23:1-24:67

Sarah's death; Isaac and Rebekah, the covenant line continues

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 87 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 23:1-24:67. This is a Long reading covering Sarah's death and burial, then the extended narrative of finding a wife for Isaac. Read steadily; do not get bogged down in the details of negotiation. The heart of these chapters is the careful preservation of the covenant line.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Twenty-five years after the call, ten years after Isaac's birth, Sarah dies at 127. Abraham, now 137, buries her in a cave he purchases from the Hittites. This is the first piece of the promised land that the patriarchal family actually owns. Then attention turns to the next generation: a wife must be found for Isaac, and it must not be a Canaanite woman. Abraham sends his trusted servant on a journey to find a wife from his own people. The result is the beautiful story of Rebekah, and the covenant line continues.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham bargains carefully and pays full price (400 shekels of silver) for the cave of Machpelah. The land is legally his.
2. Genesis 24 is the longest single chapter in Genesis, the longest piece of patriarchal narrative.
3. Abraham makes the servant swear by placing his hand under Abraham's thigh, a solemn oath, perhaps connected to circumcision.
4. The servant prays specifically for guidance and asks for a sign, and God answers his prayer before he finishes.

5. Rebekah's offer to water the camels (each drinks 20+ gallons) is the sign of her generous, hospitable character.
6. The servant attributes everything to God: "the LORD has led me" (verse 27), "the LORD has prospered my way" (verse 56).
7. Rebekah is asked, not commanded, whether she will go. Her "I will go" echoes Abraham's earlier obedience.
8. Isaac is meditating in the field at evening when Rebekah arrives. The covenant line is renewed in the next generation.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 23 and 24 are quiet chapters compared to what has come before. There is no dramatic test like Moriah, no destruction like Sodom. But they are essential to the story. Sarah dies, the first ancestor of Israel to be buried in the land of promise. And Isaac is given a wife, ensuring that the covenant line will continue.

The death of Sarah is significant. Abraham, who had been promised the land of Canaan as an everlasting possession, owns nothing in it until now. He must buy a cave from the Hittites to bury his wife. The chapter records the negotiation with great care, Abraham insists on paying full price, refusing the offer of a gift. He wants legal title. This is the first piece of the promised land that actually belongs to Abraham's family, and it is, ironically, a grave. The patriarchs will own the land as dead before they possess it as living. Their tombs become the down payment on the inheritance.

Genesis 24 then turns to the future. Abraham is concerned that Isaac not marry a Canaanite woman. The covenant family must remain distinct. So he sends his servant on a long journey back to Mesopotamia to find a wife from his own people. This is not about ethnic purity for its own sake. It is about preserving a household where the LORD will be known and the covenant will be lived out.

The chapter is remarkable for how prominently prayer features. The servant prays for guidance. He asks for a specific sign. And God answers, before the prayer is even finished, Rebekah appears. Notice how the servant attributes everything to God. He does not boast about his own perceptiveness. He says the LORD has led him, the LORD has prospered his way, the LORD has shown steadfast love. This is what biblical providence looks like in practice. A person walks in obedience, prays for guidance, and recognizes God's hand in what happens.

Rebekah is presented as the ideal partner for Isaac. She is generous, watering ten thirsty camels is no small thing. She is hospitable, inviting strangers to her family's home. She is courageous, willing to leave her home and travel to a husband she has never met. And critically, she is willing. When her family asks if she will go, she says, "I will go." Her words echo Abraham's response decades earlier: he went, when called. Now she goes, when called. The pattern of faith is repeating in a new generation.

The chapter ends with Isaac meditating in the field at evening. He looks up and sees the camels coming. Rebekah looks up and sees Isaac. They marry, and Isaac loves her. The covenant line continues. The promise is being passed to the next generation, not by accident or by mere biological succession, but by the careful providence of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Sarah's burial and Isaac's marriage are two halves of the same theme: the covenant line is being preserved across generations. The cave of Machpelah will eventually receive Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, and Leah, the first lasting presence of the covenant family in the promised land. And Rebekah's "I will go" echoes Abraham's call, preparing us for Jacob and Joseph and all who will follow in the line of faith.

STEP 6

Application

The covenant family is preserved through ordinary obedience and prayer. The servant in Genesis 24 is a model. He prays for guidance. He walks in obedience. He recognizes God's hand. He attributes every success to the LORD. Today, take his pattern with you. Pray about the decisions in front of you, however small. Walk in obedience. When good things happen, name them as gifts. The Christian life is largely the daily, quiet practice of trusting God's providence in unremarkable circumstances.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the quiet faithfulness that carried his promises forward.

Ask him to help you pray for guidance and see his hand in ordinary things.

Pray for the next generation of believers around you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

“And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness.”

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 41 · WEEK 6

Genesis 25:1-26:35

Abraham's death; Jacob and Esau; Isaac's covenant renewed

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 60 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 25:1-26:35. The first chapter records Abraham's death and the birth of Jacob and Esau. The second focuses on Isaac, his struggles with the Philistines, the renewal of the covenant to him, and Esau's marriage to Hittite women. Watch for how the patterns of Abraham's life are repeating in Isaac's.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Abraham is 175 when he dies, having lived to see Isaac married and the covenant pass to the next generation. After his death, the story narrows to Isaac. Isaac is in many ways the quietest of the patriarchs, there are fewer dramatic episodes in his life than in his father's or his son's. But this chapter shows that the covenant continues to operate. Isaac and Rebekah struggle with infertility, just as Abraham and Sarah did. Twins are born, Esau and Jacob. And the same kinds of trials and blessings that marked Abraham's life now mark Isaac's.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Abraham takes another wife, Keturah, and has more children, but Isaac alone inherits everything (25:5).
2. Abraham dies "in a good old age, an old man and full of years", the first peaceful death in the Bible.
3. Isaac and Ishmael bury Abraham together at Machpelah. Family reconciliation at the grave.
4. Rebekah is barren for twenty years. Isaac prays for her, and she conceives.
5. Two nations struggle in Rebekah's womb. God tells her: "the older shall serve the younger."

6. Esau sells his birthright for stew. The text notes: “Thus Esau despised his birthright.”
7. Genesis 26 echoes Abraham’s life in striking ways: famine, deception about a wife being a sister, conflict over wells.
8. God renews the covenant to Isaac: “I will multiply your offspring… in your offspring all the nations of the earth shall be blessed.”
9. Esau marries two Hittite women, causing grief to Isaac and Rebekah.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 25 and 26 mark a transition. The Abraham era ends; the Isaac era begins. But the patterns continue. The covenant promises are renewed. The same struggles arise. The same faithfulness of God is displayed.

Abraham’s death is significant in its peacefulness. He is described as dying “in a good old age, an old man and full of years, and was gathered to his people.” This is the first instance in Scripture of the phrase “gathered to his people”, language that suggests something more than mere burial, perhaps anticipating the reunion of the patriarchs in the life to come. Abraham’s death is not tragic but full. He has seen the promise begin to be fulfilled, and he dies in peace.

The mention of Ishmael at the burial is touching. Isaac and Ishmael, half-brothers long separated by Sarah’s demand and Hagar’s exile, come together at their father’s grave. Death often brings reconciliation. The covenant blessing passes to Isaac, but the brotherly bond between the two sons is recognized at this moment.

Then attention shifts to Isaac and Rebekah. They have been married for twenty years without children. The pattern of barrenness is repeating, the same struggle Sarah faced. The covenant family seems perpetually on the edge of extinction, and God always answers prayer just in time. Isaac prays. Rebekah conceives.

But the pregnancy is difficult. Twins are wrestling inside her. She inquires of the LORD, and God reveals the future: “Two nations are in your womb… and the older shall serve the younger.” This is the doctrine of election in narrative form. Before either child has done anything good or bad, God has chosen the younger over the older. Paul will pick this up in Romans 9 as a key proof text for God’s sovereign election. The blessing does not flow by birth order. It flows by God’s choice.

Esau and Jacob are born. Esau, the elder, becomes a man of the field, a skilled hunter, his father’s favorite. Jacob, the younger, dwells in tents and is his mother’s favorite. The stage is set for the conflict that will dominate the rest of Genesis.

The famous birthright episode shows the contrast in character. Esau comes in from the field hungry. He sees Jacob's stew. He demands it. Jacob, calculating and opportunistic, offers it in exchange for the birthright. Esau swears, eats, and goes on his way. The text's verdict is brief and damning: "Thus Esau despised his birthright." The blessing of God meant so little to him that he traded it for a meal. Hebrews 12 will hold this up as a warning to believers: do not be like Esau, who sold his blessing for a single meal.

Genesis 26 then echoes Abraham's life in striking ways. Famine drives Isaac to Gerar, the same place his father went. Isaac lies about Rebekah, calling her his sister, the same lie his father told twice. Abimelech (or his successor) again deals with the patriarch's deception. Isaac digs wells; the Philistines stop them up; conflict ensues. The patterns are remarkably similar.

But God renews the covenant to Isaac. "I will be with you and will bless you… and I will establish the oath that I swore to Abraham your father. I will multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven… and in your offspring all the nations of the earth shall be blessed." The promise made to Abraham now belongs to Isaac. The covenant is generational. It does not stop with one person; it is passed to the next.

The chapter ends with a quiet sorrow: Esau marries two Hittite women, against the covenant pattern of marrying within the covenant family. The choices of Esau will have consequences for centuries to come.

STEP 5

Connection

The covenant passes from Abraham to Isaac. The same pattern that marked Abraham, barrenness then miraculous birth, famine then provision, deception then divine protection, now marks Isaac. And the line of promise continues to narrow: not all of Isaac's children, but Jacob in particular, will carry the covenant forward. Romans 9 will return to this chapter to show that God's saving purposes operate by election, not by ethnic descent.

STEP 6

Application

Two warnings emerge from these chapters. First, do not despise your birthright. Whatever spiritual blessings God has given you, your salvation, your church, your access to Scripture, your privileged knowledge of the gospel, do not trade them for cheap satisfactions. Esau sold his birthright for stew because the stew was tangible and the birthright was not. Watch out for the daily temptation to trade eternal goods for momentary pleasures.

Second, take heart that God is faithful across generations. The covenant did not stop with Abraham. It passed to Isaac. The God who blessed your spiritual parents and grandparents is the God who blesses you, and who will bless your children if you walk in faith. The covenant is generational. Your faithfulness today shapes the spiritual inheritance of those who come after you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for carrying his covenant across generations to you.

Confess where you have despised something precious for something immediate.

Ask him to help you pass the faith to someone who comes after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 6

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

DAY 42 · WEEK 6

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed contained the binding of Isaac on Mount Moriah, one of the most theologically loaded chapters in the entire Old Testament. Take time today to let the depth of Abraham's faith, and the foreshadowing of Christ's sacrifice, settle in you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

GENESIS 15:6

REST

Meditation

Genesis 15:6 is the single most important Old Testament verse for understanding the New Testament's doctrine of salvation. Paul quotes it in Romans 4 and Galatians 3 as the proof that justification has always been by faith, never by works.

Three things are happening here. Abraham believed, faith is the means, not earning. The LORD counted, the accounting is divine, not human. And what was counted was righteousness, not credit toward future righteousness, but righteousness itself.

Say the verse and notice: Abraham did nothing to earn this. He had lied about Sarai. He would lie again. He had not yet been circumcised. He had not yet faced Moriah. And he was reckoned righteous on the basis of believing. This is grace. This is also the verdict over you, if you have believed in Christ. Carry the verse with you as the legal verdict over your life. You are reckoned righteous, not because of who you are, but because of who Christ is.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week began with Abraham's bold intercession for Sodom and the contrasting end of Lot's compromised life. It moved through the long-awaited birth of Isaac, Sarah's laughter, the fulfillment of twenty-five years of waiting. Then came Genesis 22, the binding of Isaac. The mountain of Moriah. The wood carried by the son. The ram caught in the thicket. The substitute provided by God. You worshiped with Psalm 105:23-45, which carried the patriarchal story forward into the Exodus. You watched Sarah die and Isaac receive Rebekah. And the week closed with the birth of Jacob and Esau, and the long pattern of the unloved younger son being chosen by God.

The week was about tested faith. Faith that lies sometimes. Faith that laughs in disbelief and then in fulfillment. Faith that climbs the mountain with the knife. Faith that, in spite of all its weakness, is reckoned as righteousness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What is your Isaac? Genesis 22 asks every believer this question eventually: what has God given you that you would struggle to give back to him? Name it today. Hold it loosely. The God who tested Abraham is the same God who did not spare his own Son. He has already given his most. Trust him with yours.

How does the binding of Isaac point you to the cross? Every detail of Genesis 22 anticipates Calvary, the beloved son carrying wood up the hill, the substitute provided by God, the son spared because another died. But at Moriah, the son was spared. At Calvary, the Son was not. Why does this matter? Sit with the difference today. How does the cross deepen your reading of Abraham's near-sacrifice?

Where is your faith being tested right now, and what does Genesis 15:6 say to you in the test? Faith is not the absence of weakness. Abraham was reckoned righteous even with his lies still ahead of him. If you have believed in Christ, his righteousness has been reckoned to you, and that verdict holds even when your faith feels small.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that your standing with him is righteous in Christ, not good enough by your own effort.

Ask him to show you what you are holding too tightly and to help you hold it loosely.

Thank Jesus for carrying the wood and not being spared.

DAY 43 · WEEK 7

Genesis 27:1-28:22

The stolen blessing; Jacob's ladder, election and promise

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 67 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 27:1-28:22. These chapters tell the story of Jacob stealing Esau's blessing, his flight from his brother's wrath, and his vision of the ladder at Bethel. Notice the messiness of God's election, Jacob is a deceiver, and yet God claims him as the bearer of the covenant.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Isaac is old and nearly blind. He plans to bless Esau, his favorite son, before he dies. But Rebekah overhears and concocts a scheme: Jacob will pretend to be Esau and steal the blessing. The deception works. When Esau discovers it, he plans to kill Jacob, so Jacob flees to Rebekah's family in the east. On the way, he has a dream, the famous vision of the ladder reaching to heaven, with angels ascending and descending, and the LORD himself standing above. This is one of the most theologically rich dreams in the Old Testament.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Isaac wants to bless Esau, his favorite, despite God's word that the older would serve the younger.
2. Rebekah's deception is elaborate, goat skins on Jacob's hands, Esau's clothes on his body, savory food disguised as game.
3. Isaac is suspicious but ultimately deceived. He blesses Jacob, thinking he is Esau.
4. Esau's grief is real and intense: "Bless me, even me also, O my father!" He weeps bitterly.
5. Isaac's second blessing on Esau is much weaker, Esau will live by the sword and serve his brother.

6. Esau plans to kill Jacob "as soon as Father is dead." Murderous intent toward a brother, echoes of Cain.
7. Jacob flees to Haran, sent by his parents on the pretext of finding a wife.
8. On the way, alone in the wilderness, Jacob has the dream of the ladder.
9. The angels ascend and descend on the ladder. The LORD stands above and renews the covenant promise.
10. Jacob's response: "Surely the LORD is in this place, and I did not know it." Awe meets reality.
11. He names the place Bethel ("house of God") and vows that if God brings him back safely, the LORD will be his God.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 27 and 28 are a study in the messiness of God's election. Jacob is not a hero. He is a deceiver, manipulating his blind father, profiting from his mother's scheme, stealing what God had already chosen to give him. And yet God meets him on the run and renews the covenant. This is the doctrine of grace in narrative form. God's choice does not wait for moral worthiness. It operates on the basis of his own purposes.

The deception in Genesis 27 is excruciating to read. Rebekah, who knew from the womb that Jacob would be the chosen one, does not trust God to bring it about. So she takes matters into her own hands. She prepares the deception. She gives Jacob detailed instructions. She even takes the blame herself: "Let your curse be on me, my son." Jacob, more cautious than committed, hesitates only because he might get caught, not because the deception is wrong. The scheme works. Isaac is fooled. Jacob receives the blessing meant for Esau.

The aftermath is devastating. Esau returns with the game he had hunted. Isaac trembles when he realizes what has happened. Esau cries out, one of the most painful cries in Scripture: "Bless me, even me also, O my father!" Hebrews 12 records what happened next: "He found no chance to repent, though he sought it with tears." The blessing once given could not be undone. Isaac speaks a secondary, lesser blessing over Esau, but the primary blessing is gone.

And then comes the consequence. Esau plans to kill Jacob. Rebekah, learning of this, sends Jacob away. The mother who manipulated to get her son the blessing now loses him, perhaps forever, the text suggests she never sees him again. The patriarchal family is fractured by deceit. Jacob flees with nothing but his staff. His scheming has cost him home, mother, father, and brother.

But God meets him on the road. In the wilderness, alone, with a stone for a pillow, Jacob has the dream. A ladder is set up between earth and heaven. The angels of God are ascending and descending on it. And the LORD stands above the ladder and speaks: "I am the LORD, the God of Abraham your father and the God of Isaac... and in you and your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed."

The covenant has just been renewed, to Jacob the deceiver, on the run, with nothing to commend him. This is grace. The same God who chose Jacob in the womb is choosing Jacob still. The promises made to Abraham, renewed to Isaac, are now passed to Jacob. The man does not deserve them. God gives them anyway. That is the definition of grace.

The image of the ladder is rich. It is the meeting place of heaven and earth. Angels move between the two realms. The God who seemed distant when Jacob fled is right above him. Centuries later, Jesus will tell Nathanael, "You will see heaven opened, and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man" (John 1:51). Jesus is the true ladder. He is the meeting place of heaven and earth. The dream Jacob saw was a preview of the incarnation. Jesus is the ladder that brings heaven down to those who are running from their own messes.

Jacob's response is awe. "Surely the LORD is in this place, and I did not know it... This is none other than the house of God, and this is the gate of heaven." He renames the place Bethel, "house of God." And he makes a vow: "If God will be with me and will keep me... then the LORD shall be my God." It is a tentative response, half faith, half bargaining. Jacob is not yet the man he will become. But God has met him, and the journey toward transformation has begun.

STEP 5

Connection

The covenant has now been renewed to all three patriarchs, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Each time, God renews it freely, despite the failures of the recipients. Jacob's ladder will become one of the great Christological images of the Old Testament: Jesus is the true ladder, the meeting place of heaven and earth, the one in whom the promises to Abraham finally find their fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

If God only worked through moral heroes, none of us would qualify. Jacob was a manipulator. Rebekah was a schemer. Isaac was favoring the wrong son. Esau was profane. And in the middle of this dysfunctional family, God's grace ran on, choosing, renewing, blessing. Today, take comfort from the fact that the God of Jacob is the God of imperfect

people. He is not waiting for you to clean up your act before he meets you on the road. He is the God who shows up at Bethel, wherever you are, however you got there, with whatever stones you have for pillows. Look up. The ladder is open. Christ is the meeting place. And the same covenant promises are spoken over you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he meets imperfect people on the run, and tell him where you have been running.

Thank Christ as the true ladder between heaven and earth.

Ask him to speak to you in your own wilderness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 44 · WEEK 7

Genesis 29:1-30:43

Jacob with Laban; the twelve sons; God's providence

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 76 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 29:1-30:43. Jacob arrives in Haran, meets Rachel, works for Laban, gets deceived into marrying Leah, marries Rachel as well, and fathers eleven of the twelve tribes of Israel. This is a long, complicated, messy stretch, but it is also the formation of the people of God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jacob arrives in Haran and meets Rachel at the well. He falls in love with her and agrees to work seven years for Laban as a bride price. Laban, every bit as crafty as Jacob, substitutes Leah on the wedding night. Jacob discovers the deception in the morning but must work another seven years to also marry Rachel. What follows is the painful, fertile, complicated story of how the twelve sons of Jacob, the fathers of the twelve tribes of Israel, were born. It is a story of sibling rivalry, jealousy, manipulation, and the slow forming of a nation.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jacob meets Rachel at a well, echoing his father's servant meeting Rebekah at a well.
2. Jacob falls in love at first sight and agrees to seven years of work as a bride price. The text says it seemed to him "but a few days because of the love he had for her."
3. Laban switches Leah for Rachel on the wedding night. Jacob, the deceiver, is deceived. Poetic justice.
4. Jacob must work seven more years for Rachel, but receives her immediately after the bridal week.
5. Leah is unloved but fertile; Rachel is loved but barren. The pattern of barrenness continues with the matriarchs.

6. Leah names her first four sons with theological intent: Reuben ("the LORD has seen"), Simeon ("the LORD has heard"), Levi ("attached"), Judah ("praise").
7. Bilhah and Zilpah, the maidservants, are given as concubines, a repetition of the Hagar mistake on a larger scale.
8. Twelve sons (and one daughter, Dinah) are born across the four mothers, the future twelve tribes of Israel.
9. Jacob and Laban's economic struggle (chapter 30:25-43) shows God blessing Jacob despite Laban's repeated manipulations.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two chapters cover roughly twenty years of Jacob's life, his years in Haran working for Laban, marrying both Leah and Rachel, and fathering the children who would become the twelve tribes of Israel. It is a long, painful, fertile period. And in the midst of all the dysfunction, God is forming a nation.

When Jacob arrives in Haran, he meets Rachel at a well. This is a deliberate echo of how Isaac's bride was found. The God who meets the covenant family at wells is providentially arranging marriages and futures. Jacob falls instantly in love with Rachel. He agrees to seven years of work for her hand. The text says it seemed to him "but a few days because of the love he had for her", one of the most romantic lines in the Bible.

But Laban is every bit as cunning as Jacob. On the wedding night, Laban substitutes Leah (the older sister) for Rachel. Jacob does not realize until the morning. The deception is shocking. The same Jacob who pretended to be Esau by wearing hairy goat skins is now deceived by a woman wearing a wedding veil. The deceiver is deceived. This is one of the Bible's clearest examples of divine justice working through ordinary circumstances. What Jacob did to Esau and Isaac, Laban now does to him. He reaps what he sowed.

But there is more here. The substitution of Leah for Rachel, the unloved sister for the loved one, sets up one of the great tensions of the rest of Genesis. Leah is "not loved" by Jacob (the Hebrew is striking, "hated" is too strong but "less loved" is too soft). And yet God sees her. He opens her womb while Rachel remains barren. Leah's first four sons are named with such theological intent: Reuben means "the LORD has seen my affliction." Simeon means "the LORD has heard that I am hated." Levi means "attached" (perhaps hoping Jacob will be attached to her). Judah means "praise", by the fourth son, Leah stops naming her babies in relation to her husband and starts naming them in praise to God. This is a profound shift. She has learned to find her satisfaction in the LORD rather than in the love of her husband.

And critically, it is Leah, not Rachel, who becomes the mother of Judah. Judah will be the tribe of David. Judah will be the tribe of Christ. The "loved" wife was barren; the "unloved" wife bore the line of Messiah. This is grace's preference for the overlooked.

The two maidservants, Bilhah and Zilpah, are then given to Jacob as concubines. This is a repetition of the Hagar mistake at a larger scale. Just as Sarah tried to fulfill the promise through Hagar, Rachel and Leah try to compete with each other through their servants. The result is twelve sons born across four mothers, in a household full of jealousy and rivalry. This is hardly the picture of a holy family. And yet, these twelve sons will become the twelve tribes of Israel. God forms the nation through this dysfunctional household.

Genesis 30 ends with a long economic conflict between Jacob and Laban. Laban has been cheating Jacob for years. Now Jacob, in turn, engineers a complicated breeding scheme that results in his flocks growing rapidly while Laban's diminish. The text is careful to note that God is the one prospering Jacob, but Jacob is hardly innocent in his methods. The two crafty men are locked in a battle of wits, and God uses it to make Jacob prosperous so he can eventually leave Haran with the resources to start a new life.

STEP 5

Connection

The twelve sons of Jacob are the foundation of the nation of Israel. The twelve tribes named in this chapter, Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Issachar, Zebulun, Joseph, Benjamin (born later), will become the structure of Israel for the next thousand years. Judah, in particular, will become the tribe of David, and from Judah will come Christ. The unloved wife Leah is therefore the great-great-grandmother of the Messiah. God's redemptive plan ran through the despised.

STEP 6

Application

If God can form his people out of this household, full of deception, jealousy, polygamy, and rivalry, he can form his people out of anything. Take heart if your own family or community feels too broken for God to use. Take heart if you yourself feel too tangled to be useful. The God of Jacob is the God of complicated stories. He works with what is, not with idealizations of what should be.

And if you feel unloved or overlooked, like Leah, remember that she is the one through whom Christ came. God sees those who are not seen by the world. He gives praise to the lips of those who have been demoted by others. The line that mattered most ran through her, not through the favored sister.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that no family story is too tangled for him to redeem, and name one in your own life.

Ask him to help you see and care for the overlooked as he did.

Tell him what you want to praise him for, as Leah learned to.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

“Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go.”

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 45 · WEEK 7

Psalm 121

The LORD is your keeper, the pilgrim's confidence

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 121 twice. This is one of the most beloved psalms in the Bible, the second of the Psalms of Ascent, sung by pilgrims journeying up to Jerusalem. It is a perfect psalm for Jacob's journey, and for yours.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 121 belongs to a group of fifteen psalms (Psalms 120-134) called the Psalms of Ascent. These were sung by Jewish pilgrims as they traveled up to Jerusalem for the great feasts. They are psalms of the road, of journey, danger, trust, and arrival. Psalm 121 specifically is a meditation on God as the keeper of his people on their pilgrimage. After several days walking through the Jacob narrative, the deceiver fleeing from home, traveling alone, having visions and disputes, this psalm is the appropriate pause. It teaches us how to pray as we travel.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1: "I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come?" The hills could be a source of danger or a reminder of God's dwelling.
2. Verse 2 answers: "My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth." The Creator is the keeper.
3. The word "keep" (Hebrew shamar) appears six times in eight verses, it is the spine of the psalm.
4. Verse 3: "He will not let your foot be moved; he who keeps you will not slumber." Constant vigilance.
5. Verse 4 expands: "Behold, he who keeps Israel will neither slumber nor sleep." God never rests off duty.

6. Verse 5: “The LORD is your keeper; the LORD is your shade on your right hand.” Protective presence.
7. Verses 7-8: “The LORD will keep you from all evil; he will keep your life. The LORD will keep your going out and your coming in, from this time forth and forevermore.” All-encompassing protection.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 121 is the song of the pilgrim. It begins with a question, “From where does my help come?”, and answers it definitively. Help comes from the LORD, the maker of heaven and earth. Everything else in the psalm flows from that initial confession.

The word that holds the psalm together is “keep”, shamar in Hebrew. It appears six times in just eight verses. The LORD keeps you. He keeps Israel. He keeps your life. He keeps your going out and your coming in. The psalm is essentially a meditation on the fact that God is the keeper of his people. He does not just save them; he keeps them. Salvation is the moment of rescue; keeping is the long, daily, faithful work of preservation that follows.

The psalm makes striking claims about God’s keeping. He will not let your foot be moved. He will not slumber. He will not sleep. These are claims about the unceasing vigilance of God. In a world where every other guardian eventually fails, sleeps, dies, looks away, God never does. The keeper of Israel is awake right now. The keeper of Israel is awake while you sleep. The keeper of Israel is awake when you are unconscious in surgery, when you are flying across oceans, when you are walking through your worst day. He never slumbers.

Verse 5 introduces a beautiful image: “The LORD is your shade on your right hand.” In the ancient Near East, shade was life. The sun beat down relentlessly, and shade was the difference between survival and death. God is shade, the merciful protection that makes life possible. And he is on your right hand, the closest position, the most attentive position.

The psalm closes with a promise that extends in every direction. The LORD will keep you from all evil. He will keep your life. He will keep your going out and your coming in. Every direction of travel, every threshold you cross, every door you walk through, God keeps. And the time frame is total: from this time forth and forevermore. The keeping does not end. Even death does not interrupt it. The same God who keeps you now will keep you through your final breath and into the life to come.

STEP 5

Connection

Jacob, fleeing from Esau, alone in the wilderness, dreamed of a ladder and heard the covenant promise renewed. Now he is on the long pilgrimage of Genesis 29-31, journeying through years of hard labor and difficult relationships. This psalm could have been his, a song for the pilgrim, sung by anyone who is walking through uncertain seasons. And it is yours, too. The God who kept Jacob is the God who keeps you.

STEP 6

Application

Today, lift your eyes. Wherever you are, whatever you are facing, lift your eyes from the immediate to the eternal. Your help is not in your own resources, your own planning, your own strength. Your help comes from the LORD, the maker of heaven and earth. The same God who flung galaxies into space is keeping you right now. He has not slumbered. He has not slept. His shade is on your right hand at this very moment.

And take comfort that God keeps "your going out and your coming in." This is total coverage. The mundane comings and goings of your day, the commute to work, the trip to the grocery store, the school pickup, the walk to the mailbox, all of it is under his keeping. There are no insignificant moments to a God who keeps every coming and going. He is involved in your whole life, not just the dramatic parts. Receive his keeping today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Lift your eyes to God and tell him where you need help today.
- Thank him that he never slumbers and is keeping you right now.
- Ask him to keep your going out and your coming in.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 46 · WEEK 7

Psalm 124; Psalm 125

If the LORD had not been on our side

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 124 and Psalm 125 slowly, twice. Both are Psalms of Ascent. Psalm 124 looks back at past deliverance; Psalm 125 looks forward in confident trust. Together they are the song of those who have walked through hardship and arrived at certainty about who God is.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We continue the Psalms of Ascent. Psalm 124 is attributed to David and reflects on what would have happened to Israel if the LORD had not been on their side. Psalm 125 then offers confident trust, those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved. Together they capture both the memory and the hope of God's people. They are perfect songs for those who have made it through difficulty and are walking by faith toward the future.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Psalm 124 opens with a hypothetical: "If it had not been the LORD who was on our side…", followed by vivid pictures of what would have happened.
2. The threats described are dramatic: men rising up, being swallowed alive, the floods sweeping us away, the torrent going over our soul.
3. Verse 6 turns to praise: "Blessed be the LORD, who has not given us as prey to their teeth!"
4. The bird-and-snare image (verse 7) captures the suddenness of God's deliverance.
5. The psalm closes with the same confession as Psalm 121:2, "Our help is in the name of the LORD, who made heaven and earth."

6. Psalm 125:1 opens with a simile: “Those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved.”
7. Verse 2: “As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the LORD surrounds his people, from this time forth and forevermore.”
8. The psalm acknowledges the threat of evil (the “scepter of wickedness”) but promises it will not “rest on the land allotted to the righteous.”
9. It closes with the prayer: “Peace be upon Israel!”

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two short psalms complement one another. The first remembers past rescue. The second confidently anticipates future stability. Together they form the bipolar prayer of the believer: gratitude for what God has done, confidence in what God will do.

Psalm 124 begins with one of the most striking rhetorical devices in the Psalter. “If it had not been the LORD who was on our side…” And then the psalmist runs through the disasters that would have followed: enemies would have swallowed them alive, floods would have swept them away, torrents would have gone over their souls. The whole psalm is built on the contrary-to-fact conditional. If God had not acted, this would have happened. But God did act, and so we are here, singing.

This is one of the most important habits the believer can cultivate. Look back at your life and ask, Where did God intervene? Where did things turn out differently than they could have? The Christian’s memory is not random. It is curated by the Spirit to recall the acts of God. Every time you remember a deliverance, you are doing what Psalm 124 does. You are putting words to what would have been, in order to celebrate what is.

The bird-and-snare image of verse 7 is one of the most evocative pictures of rescue in the Psalter. “We have escaped like a bird from the snare of the fowlers; the snare is broken, and we have escaped!” Anyone who has ever felt trapped, by sin, by circumstance, by fear, by depression, knows what this image describes. The snare is real. The bird really is caught. And then suddenly the snare breaks and the bird is in the air. That is what salvation feels like.

Psalm 125 then turns to the future. “Those who trust in the LORD are like Mount Zion, which cannot be moved, but abides forever.” This is a remarkable promise. Those who trust in the LORD are themselves like Mount Zion, solid, enduring, eternal. Their faith is not just an internal feeling; it produces a kind of life that cannot be shaken. They become, in their very being, immovable.

And the image expands. “As the mountains surround Jerusalem, so the LORD surrounds his people.” Jerusalem is in the Judean hills, ringed by mountains on every side. The natural fortification was significant in ancient warfare. But the psalmist says God himself is the surrounding mountains around his people. Wherever the LORD’s people are, they are surrounded by his presence and protection. And this surrounding is permanent: from this time forth and forevermore.

The psalm is realistic about evil. The “scepter of wickedness” does come upon the land. But it will not rest there permanently. And the psalm closes with the simplest of prayers: “Peace be upon Israel!” Shalom, wholeness, flourishing, the fullness of God’s blessing.

STEP 5

Connection

The Psalms of Ascent fit naturally with Jacob’s life. His life has been a pilgrimage, flight from home, years in Haran, return to Canaan, descent into Egypt to come. The believer’s life is similarly a pilgrimage. We are journeying through this age toward our true home. These psalms teach us how to walk: looking back in gratitude, looking forward in trust, surrounded by the presence of the LORD.

STEP 6

Application

Practice two habits today. First, the habit of Psalm 124: look back. Take a few minutes today to remember one specific way God intervened in your life. Maybe it was a near accident avoided. Maybe it was a relationship saved. Maybe it was a sin you almost committed but didn’t. Maybe it was a prayer answered just in time. Name it. Thank him for it. Tell someone about it.

Second, the habit of Psalm 125: trust. Receive the promise that you, trusting in the LORD, are like Mount Zion. You cannot be ultimately shaken. The same mountains that surround Jerusalem are the encircling presence of God around your life. Whatever feels unstable today, your foundation is not. Pray Psalm 125 over yourself: I trust in the LORD. I am like Mount Zion. He surrounds me. Peace be upon me, in his name.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Bless the LORD for a time he did not let you be overwhelmed, and tell him about it.

Thank him for the snares he has broken in your life.

Ask him to make your trust as settled as the mountains that surround Jerusalem.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

“Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go.”

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 47 · WEEK 7

Genesis 31:1-32:32

Jacob departs Laban; wrestling with God at Jabbok

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 31:1-32:32. Jacob finally leaves Laban, faces him in a confrontation, and then prepares to meet Esau. The chapter climaxes with the famous wrestling match at the Jabbok, where Jacob becomes Israel.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jacob has spent twenty years working for Laban. Now the LORD tells him to return to the land of his fathers. He leaves secretly, taking his wives, children, and flocks. Laban pursues, the two confront one another, and they part with an uneasy treaty. But the bigger fear ahead is Esau. The brother Jacob deceived twenty years ago is on his way to meet him with four hundred men. The night before the meeting, Jacob is left alone, and there he wrestles with a mysterious man until dawn. The encounter changes everything.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God tells Jacob to return, verse 3: “Return to the land of your fathers and to your kindred, and I will be with you.”
2. Rachel steals her father’s household gods, an action Jacob does not know about, but which puts the family in danger.
3. Laban pursues, accuses, searches, and ultimately makes a treaty with Jacob. The mound of stones (Mizpah) is the witness.
4. Jacob then faces Esau. He prays, the first recorded prayer of Jacob (32:9-12), recalling God’s promise.
5. He sends elaborate gifts ahead to appease Esau. Practical wisdom alongside prayer.

6. Alone at night, he wrestles with a “man” until daybreak. The man cannot prevail by force but disables Jacob’s hip.
7. Jacob refuses to let go without a blessing. He gets one, and a new name: Israel (“he strives with God”).
8. Jacob names the place Peniel (“face of God”), “I have seen God face to face, and yet my life has been delivered.”
9. He walks away limping. The wound is permanent.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 32 contains one of the most mysterious and important events in the Old Testament. Jacob wrestles all night with a man who turns out to be God. He emerges with a new name, a permanent limp, and a new identity.

The chapter is set up by Jacob’s fear. He is returning to face the brother he deceived. He is convinced Esau will kill him. So he prepares in three ways. First, he prays, the first recorded prayer of Jacob in Scripture, and it is full of acknowledged unworthiness: “I am not worthy of the least of all the deeds of steadfast love and all the faithfulness that you have shown to your servant.” Twenty years of dealing with Laban have humbled Jacob. He is no longer the confident schemer of Genesis 27. Second, he sends gifts ahead, wave after wave of livestock, to soften Esau’s heart. Third, he divides his family into two camps, so that if one is attacked, the other might escape.

Then night falls, and Jacob is left alone. A man comes and wrestles him until dawn. The text is deliberately ambiguous at first about who this man is. He is strong but cannot prevail by force. He touches Jacob’s hip and dislocates it. He pleads to be released as dawn breaks. Jacob refuses unless he receives a blessing. The man asks for Jacob’s name, and Jacob, for the first time honestly, admits “Jacob.” The name means “deceiver, supplanter.” Jacob is finally confessing who he has been.

And the man renames him. “Your name shall no longer be called Jacob, but Israel, for you have striven with God and with men, and have prevailed.” Israel means “he strives with God” or “God strives.” Jacob’s identity is fundamentally remade. The deceiver becomes the striver. The man who has spent his life manipulating now becomes the man who wrestles God face to face.

Jacob asks the man’s name. The man does not give it. Instead, he blesses Jacob and departs. Jacob, awestruck, names the place Peniel, “face of God”, and says, “I have seen God face to face, and yet my life has been delivered.” This was no ordinary man. This was the LORD himself, in some form that allowed face-to-face encounter without destroying Jacob.

And Jacob walks away limping. The wound is permanent. From this night forward, his body bears the mark of his wrestling with God. The point is profound. Encounter with God always leaves a mark. You do not walk away from God unchanged. The limp is not weakness; it is testimony. Every step Jacob takes for the rest of his life is a reminder that he met God and lived.

STEP 5

Connection

Jacob the deceiver becomes Israel, the name his descendants will bear for all of history. The covenant family now has its national name. And the wrestling at Peniel is a vivid picture of the believer's relationship with God: it is a struggle, but it is also intimate; it is wounding, but it is also blessing; it leaves us limping, but it gives us a new identity.

STEP 6

Application

Have you wrestled with God? Not in the casual sense, but in the deep sense, staying with him in prayer even when it feels like fighting, holding on for a blessing you cannot articulate, refusing to let go until something is changed in you. This is what serious prayer becomes for the maturing believer. It is not always pleasant. It may leave you limping. But it gives you a new name. Today, if there is something you have been wrestling with God about, a fear, a calling, a relationship, a deep question about your own identity, do not let go. Hold on. The blessing comes at dawn.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly where you need to wrestle with him, and what you want from him.
- Ask him to show you who he is making you to be.
- Ask him to help you walk in what you have met of him, even if it leaves a mark.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 48 · WEEK 7

Genesis 33:1-35:29

Reconciliation with Esau; Dinah; Bethel revisited

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 33:1-35:29. Jacob meets Esau and is received in unexpected love. Then comes the tragic Dinah episode. Then God calls Jacob back to Bethel, where the covenant is renewed and Rachel dies in childbirth.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The dreaded reunion with Esau is not what Jacob expected. Esau runs to meet him, embraces him, and weeps. The brothers reconcile, at least for the moment. But the next chapter is one of the most painful in Genesis: the rape of Dinah and the violent revenge of her brothers Simeon and Levi. After this disaster, God calls Jacob back to Bethel, where his journey began with the ladder vision. The covenant is renewed, and Rachel dies giving birth to Benjamin, the last of the twelve sons.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Esau runs to meet Jacob, embraces him, falls on his neck, and weeps. The reunion is more tender than Jacob expected.
2. Jacob calls Esau's face "like seeing the face of God", connecting the reconciliation to his Peniel encounter.
3. The brothers separate again. Reconciliation does not always mean continued closeness.
4. Dinah is raped by Shechem, son of the local ruler. The text is candid about the assault.
5. Simeon and Levi deceitfully arrange the circumcision of all the men, then attack while they are recovering. Mass murder.

6. Jacob rebukes them, but for pragmatic reasons, not moral ones. He fears retaliation, not the immorality of his sons.
7. God calls Jacob back to Bethel. He instructs the household to put away foreign gods, a partial reform.
8. The covenant is renewed at Bethel: "I am God Almighty: be fruitful and multiply." The Abrahamic promises are reaffirmed.
9. Rachel dies giving birth to Benjamin. She is buried near Bethlehem.
10. Isaac dies at the end of the chapter, and Esau and Jacob bury him together.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These three chapters cover a remarkable range, from joyful reunion to brutal violence to renewed covenant to family death. They are the swirling middle of Jacob's life.

The meeting with Esau confounds expectation. Jacob has been terrified for twenty years. He has prayed, sent gifts, divided his family. And Esau runs to him, embraces him, and weeps. The God who blessed Jacob at Peniel has also been at work in Esau. The brother Jacob defrauded has somehow let go of the wrong. They reconcile, at least for the moment. Notice Jacob's striking words: "I have seen your face, which is like seeing the face of God." Jacob is connecting his encounter with Esau to his encounter with God the night before. To see the face of someone you have wronged, and to be received in love, that is, in some sense, to see the face of God.

The brothers do not continue traveling together. Jacob declines Esau's invitation to live near him. Reconciliation does not always mean continued closeness. Sometimes the right thing after forgiveness is to let go and live separately. This is wisdom.

Genesis 34 is one of the hardest chapters in Genesis. Dinah, Jacob's only daughter, is raped by Shechem. Shechem then claims to love her and seeks marriage. Simeon and Levi, two of Dinah's brothers, deceive Shechem's people, telling them they will give Dinah in marriage if all the men of the city are circumcised. When the men are weakened and recovering from the procedure, Simeon and Levi attack and kill them all, plundering the city and taking the women and children captive. It is mass murder.

Jacob's response is notable for what it is not. He does not rebuke his sons for their wickedness, only for the danger they have put the family in. "You have brought trouble on me by making me stink to the inhabitants of the land." This is pragmatic concern, not moral

confrontation. Jacob's parenting failures are evident. His silence at moral evil, first with Dinah, now with the sons' revenge, will haunt the family for generations. Genesis 49 will record his deathbed cursing of Simeon and Levi's anger.

But God calls Jacob back to Bethel. The journey that began there twenty years ago must end there. Jacob instructs his household to put away foreign gods. This is a partial reform, Jacob's household has been carrying idols all this time, and only now does he address it. The text is honest about how slow holiness is, even in the chosen family.

At Bethel, God appears again and renews the covenant. The promises given to Abraham, renewed to Isaac, renewed to Jacob at the ladder, are renewed once more. The God who began with Jacob is faithful to finish.

Then Rachel dies giving birth to Benjamin. The beloved wife of Jacob, the woman he worked fourteen years for, dies in labor. She names her son Ben-Oni ("son of my sorrow"), but Jacob renames him Benjamin ("son of my right hand"). The grief of the family is real, but the line of promise continues. The twelfth son is born. The twelve tribes are now complete.

The chapter closes with Isaac's death and burial. Esau and Jacob bury their father together at Machpelah. The patriarchs are being gathered to their people one by one.

STEP 5

Connection

The renewal of the covenant at Bethel ties Jacob's life full circle. He left there a fleeing deceiver; he returns as a wrestling man with a new name. The covenant promises remain unchanged. And the twelve sons are now complete, the twelve tribes that will become Israel.

STEP 6

Application

Reconciliation is possible. The brother you cannot face today, the wound you cannot imagine being healed, God can do it. Esau forgave Jacob, and the impossibility became reality. But also, reconciliation does not always mean continued closeness. Sometimes wisdom is to forgive and live separately. Both are biblical. Both are valid.

And take seriously the cost of parental silence. Jacob did not confront the moral evil in his own sons, and the consequences echo for generations. If you have children, or have influence over young people, speak up. Not just about danger, but about wickedness itself. Silence at evil teaches the next generation that evil is acceptable.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring a strained relationship to God, and ask what he would have you do.
- Ask him for the courage to name wrong where you see it, in love.
- Ask him to renew your commitment to him at the places you have wandered from.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 7

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

DAY 49 · WEEK 7

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed followed Jacob, the deceiver, through his deepest crisis and into his transformation. Take time today to sit with the God who meets his people on the run.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Behold, I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

GENESIS 28:15

REST

Meditation

Genesis 28:15 is the promise God spoke to Jacob at Bethel, to a man who had just deceived his father, stolen his brother's blessing, and was fleeing for his life. He had nothing to commend him to God. And God said: "I am with you and will keep you wherever you go."

This is grace at its purest. The promise is not conditional on Jacob's behavior. It is unilateral. Notice the verbs, God will keep, God will bring, God will not leave. The promise rests entirely on God's faithfulness, not on Jacob's.

Say the verse to yourself. Hear the word "keep" as we heard it in Psalm 121 this week, the LORD as your keeper, never slumbering, watching over your going out and your coming in. Wherever you go, to work, into difficult relationships, into hard seasons, God is with you. By the end of this week, this verse should be your daily reminder that you are not alone.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week followed Jacob's whole arc. You read his stealing of Esau's blessing and his flight from home, and then the ladder vision at Bethel, where the covenant was renewed to a deceiver on the run. You watched him spend twenty years with Laban, marry Leah and Rachel, father eleven of the twelve tribes. You sang Psalm 121, the LORD as your keeper, and the Psalms of Ascent that followed. And then came Jacob's wrestling at Peniel, where he received a new name: Israel. And finally his reunion with Esau, where the brother he had wronged ran to him with embrace and tears.

The week's theme is transformation. Jacob the deceiver becomes Israel the striver. The man who manipulated for blessing learns to wrestle for it. And the God who began with him at Bethel keeps him through every twist of his road home.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where has God met you "on the run", in a season when you did not deserve it? Jacob was fleeing his consequences when God appeared at Bethel. Not as a reward for his obedience, but as grace in the middle of his failure. Name a moment in your own life when God met you despite you. How does that memory shape how you receive his grace today?

How does Jacob's wrestling at Peniel point you to Christ? Jacob wrestled with God and emerged with a new name, a permanent limp, and a blessing. The Christian's wrestling with God in prayer is not a struggle against an enemy but a struggle with a Father, and through Christ, every wrestling believer emerges with a new name and a blessing too. Where are you wrestling right now? What blessing are you holding out for?

What does it mean that "God is with you wherever you go"? Today, take the promise of Genesis 28:15 into the specifics of your week, your work, your home, your hardest relationships, the places where you feel most alone. God is with you in each. What would change if you really believed this?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he meets people who have nothing to commend them, and tell him where you need him to meet you.

Ask him to wrestle with you where he must, not to destroy you but to bless you.

Rest this Sabbath in Christ, the true ladder between heaven and earth.

DAY 50 · WEEK 8

Genesis 36:1-37:36

Esau's line; Joseph sold into Egypt, the Christ-type

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 36:1-37:36. The first chapter is Esau's genealogy. The second begins the Joseph narrative, the dreams, the brothers' hatred, the selling into slavery. Read the genealogy briefly and focus your attention on chapter 37.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Before turning to Joseph's story, Genesis pauses to record Esau's descendants, the Edomites. This is the standard biblical pattern: the line of promise narrows by first noting what happens to the other line. Esau gets a chapter. Then attention returns to Jacob's family and to Joseph. The chapter that follows introduces one of the longest sustained narratives in the Bible, the Joseph story, which will run for thirteen chapters to the end of Genesis. Joseph is seventeen years old, his father's favorite, gifted with prophetic dreams, and hated by his brothers. Today's reading ends with him in chains, on his way to Egypt.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Genesis 36 is the Edomite genealogy. Esau becomes a nation in his own right.
2. The chapter is included as a record but signals that Esau is now off the main path of God's redemptive purposes.
3. Genesis 37 opens: "Jacob lived in the land of his father's sojournings." The journey home is complete.
4. Joseph is seventeen, working with his brothers, and bringing bad reports of them to his father.
5. Jacob loves Joseph more than the others and makes him a special robe, a "coat of many colors" or a long-sleeved garment.

6. Joseph has two dreams. In the first, his brothers' sheaves bow to his. In the second, the sun, moon, and eleven stars bow to him.
7. Even Jacob rebukes Joseph for the second dream, but "kept the saying in mind" (verse 11).
8. The brothers see Joseph approaching at Dothan and plot to kill him. Reuben tries to save him; Judah suggests selling him instead.
9. Joseph is sold to Ishmaelite traders for twenty shekels of silver. He is taken to Egypt.
10. The brothers dip his coat in goat's blood and deceive Jacob, who "tore his garments and put sackcloth on his loins."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 37 begins one of the most extended narratives in the Bible. The Joseph story will run thirteen chapters and dominate the rest of Genesis. It is a story of providence, suffering, betrayal, and reversal. And it begins with one of the most dysfunctional family scenes in the Old Testament.

Joseph is seventeen. He is Rachel's son, Jacob's favorite wife's firstborn, and so Jacob favors him. Jacob makes him a special robe, marking him out as the heir apparent. This favoritism is the same fault Jacob's own parents had, and the consequences are predictable. The brothers hate Joseph. They cannot speak peaceably to him.

Joseph does not help. He tells his brothers about his dreams, dreams in which they bow down to him. He brings their father bad reports about them. He is, by any honest reading, an entitled and immature young man. The text does not glorify Joseph in his teenage years. He is being prepared by God for greatness, but he is not yet great.

The plot to kill Joseph is chilling. The brothers see him approaching at Dothan, sent by his father to check on them, and they say, "Here comes this dreamer." They decide to kill him and throw him into a pit. Reuben, the oldest, tries to save Joseph by suggesting they not shed blood but throw him into a pit alive (intending to rescue him later). Then Judah, recognizing they could profit from selling Joseph, suggests they sell him to Ishmaelite traders. Joseph is sold for twenty shekels of silver.

This is the Old Testament's first sale of a person for money. The price, twenty shekels, is the value of a young male slave in the ancient Near East. The deal is done quickly, and Joseph is on his way to Egypt before the brothers have even finished celebrating.

They then deceive Jacob with Joseph's bloodied robe. The deceiver is deceived again. The same Jacob who fooled Isaac with goat skins and savory food is now fooled by his sons with goat's blood and Joseph's coat. The Hebrew is striking: "Identify, please", the same words Jacob's brothers say to him are the words Tamar will later say to Judah in chapter 38. The patterns of deception keep circling back.

Jacob's grief is total. He tears his clothes, puts on sackcloth, and refuses to be comforted. "I shall go down to Sheol to my son, mourning." The favorite son is gone. The light of Jacob's life has been extinguished. He has no idea that Joseph is alive, much less that Joseph will one day save the whole family.

But notice the last sentence of the chapter. "Meanwhile the Midianites had sold him in Egypt to Potiphar, an officer of Pharaoh, the captain of the guard." Joseph is in Egypt. The story is not over. What looks from the ground like total loss is, from heaven's perspective, the careful providential placement of a Hebrew son in the household of an Egyptian official. The God who promised Abraham four hundred years in Egypt is moving the pieces.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph's descent into Egypt is the beginning of the fulfillment of God's prophecy to Abram in Genesis 15:13, "your offspring will be sojourners in a land that is not theirs and will be servants there." The four hundred years of Egyptian sojourning that culminates in the Exodus begins right here, with one teenage boy in chains on his way south.

STEP 6

Application

The worst day of Joseph's life, being sold into slavery by his own brothers, was the start of God's plan to save his family. This is sobering and hopeful. The events that seem most catastrophic in your life may be the very means by which God is positioning you for what he intends to do. You may not see it. Joseph certainly did not see it as the chains were clinking. But God's hand is in things you cannot trace.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God about a hardship, betrayal, or loss that you cannot yet make sense of.

Ask him to help you trust that he is at work even when you cannot see it.

Ask for eyes to see later what he was doing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 51 · WEEK 8

Genesis 38:1-39:23

Judah and Tamar; Joseph in Potiphar's house

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 53 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 38:1-39:23. Chapter 38 is the strange and difficult Judah-Tamar story, a pause in the Joseph narrative. Chapter 39 returns to Joseph in Potiphar's house. The two chapters together show the contrasting characters of two of Jacob's sons.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The Joseph narrative pauses for a chapter to tell the story of Judah, the brother who suggested selling Joseph. Judah leaves the family, marries a Canaanite woman, has three sons, and then, through a strange series of events, finds himself confronted by his daughter-in-law Tamar with his own moral failure. The chapter is uncomfortable but theologically crucial. After Judah, attention returns to Joseph in Egypt, where his integrity in Potiphar's house leads first to promotion and then to imprisonment on false charges.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Judah leaves his family and marries a Canaanite, exactly what Abraham forbade Isaac from doing.
2. His first two sons, Er and Onan, both die under God's judgment for wickedness.
3. Judah sends Tamar back to her father's house, promising her his third son when he is older, a promise he breaks.
4. Tamar, denied her right, disguises herself as a prostitute and sleeps with Judah, who pledges his signet, cord, and staff.
5. When Tamar is found pregnant, Judah orders her burned, until she produces his signet, cord, and staff.

6. Judah's confession is honest: "She is more righteous than I." He acknowledges his sin.
7. Tamar bears twins. Perez (whose name appears in the genealogy of Christ) is born first.
8. Chapter 39: Joseph is now in Potiphar's house. The LORD is with him, and "all that he did, the LORD made it succeed."
9. Potiphar's wife repeatedly tries to seduce Joseph. He refuses, fleeing one day and leaving his garment behind.
10. She falsely accuses Joseph, and he is thrown into prison. Even there, "the LORD was with Joseph and showed him steadfast love."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 38 and 39 are a study in contrasts. Judah, the brother who proposed selling Joseph, drifts away from the family, marries a Canaanite, and falls into serious moral failure. Joseph, the brother sold into slavery, lives in moral integrity in a foreign land. Both stories are essential to what comes next.

The Judah-Tamar story is strange and uncomfortable, but it is in the Bible for important reasons. First, it shows Judah's character at his worst. He treats Tamar as disposable, breaking his promise to give her his third son. He treats her again as disposable when he sleeps with what he thinks is a prostitute. And he is ready to have her burned to death when her pregnancy is discovered, until he learns the child is his. The chapter is devastating in its portrait of Judah's hypocrisy and double standard.

But it is also redemptive. When confronted with the evidence, Judah confesses: "She is more righteous than I." This is the first time in Genesis we see Judah taking honest moral responsibility. It is the seed of his eventual transformation. The Judah who emerges from chapter 38 chastened will be a different man than the Judah who proposed selling Joseph. And by chapter 44, he will be the one who offers himself in Benjamin's place, a foreshadowing of Christ himself.

The chapter is also significant because Perez, Tamar's son, becomes an ancestor of David and of Christ. The Messiah's lineage runs through this messy story, through a daughter-in-law disguised as a prostitute, through a patriarch caught in his hypocrisy. Matthew 1:3 names them: "Judah the father of Perez and Zerah by Tamar." Even the scandalous becomes part of God's redemptive plan.

Then Genesis 39 returns to Joseph. He is now a slave in the house of Potiphar, captain of Pharaoh's guard. And the text immediately strikes its theme: "The LORD was with Joseph, and he became a successful man." The phrase "the LORD was with Joseph" appears multiple

times in the chapter. It is the key to everything. Joseph is in a foreign land, far from his family, working for a pagan master, and the LORD is with him. The covenant God of his fathers does not stay in Canaan. He travels with his people into exile.

Potiphar quickly recognizes Joseph's competence and gives him oversight of the entire household. Joseph rises from slave to chief of staff. Then comes the test. Potiphar's wife, Joseph's master's wife, repeatedly tries to seduce him. Joseph refuses, day after day. His refusal includes a profound theological statement: "How then can I do this great wickedness and sin against God?" Joseph does not just say he would be wronging Potiphar. He says he would be sinning against God. All sin is ultimately against God, regardless of the human parties involved.

One day Potiphar's wife grabs his garment. Joseph flees, leaving the garment behind. She uses it as false evidence and accuses him of attempted rape. Potiphar throws him in prison. Joseph has done everything right, and the result is worse than before. Demoted from rising star to prisoner. But the chapter closes with the same theme: "The LORD was with Joseph and showed him steadfast love and gave him favor in the sight of the keeper of the prison." Wherever Joseph is, slave, manager, prisoner, the LORD is with him.

STEP 5

Connection

Judah's confession (Genesis 38) and Joseph's integrity (Genesis 39) both serve the larger story. Judah is being prepared for transformation; Joseph is being prepared for elevation. And critically, both are being prepared to be ancestors in the line of Christ. Judah's son Perez will be in Matthew 1. Joseph will save the family that brings forth the Messiah.

STEP 6

Application

Two contrasts to take with you. First, Judah teaches us about the deceptive drift of mixing with the world. He left the covenant family, married outside it, treated others as disposable. The drift was slow but devastating. Examine your own life. Where are you drifting? Second, Joseph teaches us about integrity in exile. Far from family, far from familiar worship, in a culture hostile to his values, Joseph refused to compromise. He said no to a powerful woman's advances, even when no one would have known. The LORD was with him in his integrity. The LORD is with you in yours.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where you have drifted, as Judah did, or been tempted, as Joseph was.

Ask him for strength to flee sin when no one would know.

Thank him that he is with you in any place where you feel far from home or unfairly treated.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

“The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed.”

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 52 · WEEK 8

Psalm 37:1-22

Do not fret; trust in the LORD, providence over the wicked

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 22 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 37:1-22 slowly, twice. This is a wisdom psalm, a long meditation on the apparent prosperity of the wicked and the patient confidence of the righteous. It is the perfect psalm for those who have been reading about Joseph's unjust suffering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 37 is one of the great wisdom psalms, long, calm, deliberate. It addresses the question that has haunted believers in every generation: why do the wicked seem to prosper while the righteous suffer? David's answer is patience and trust. Do not fret. Do not envy. The wicked will fade like grass; the righteous will inherit the land. The psalm fits Joseph's situation exactly, he has just been imprisoned for refusing to sin, while the wicked seem to triumph.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with three commands: "Fret not... be not envious... Trust in the LORD."
2. The wicked are compared to grass that quickly fades.
3. Verse 4: "Delight yourself in the LORD, and he will give you the desires of your heart."
4. Verse 5: "Commit your way to the LORD; trust in him." The verb "commit" literally means "roll", roll your way onto him.
5. Verse 7: "Be still before the LORD and wait patiently for him." Stillness and waiting are part of righteousness.
6. Verse 11 anticipates Jesus' Beatitude: "The meek shall inherit the land."
7. The contrast continues: the wicked plot and gnash their teeth, but the LORD laughs because he sees their day coming.

8 Verse 18: “The LORD knows the days of the blameless, and their heritage will remain forever.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 37 is one of the wisest psalms in the Psalter. It does not deny that the wicked prosper. It does not pretend life is fair. It accepts the painful reality and then offers the corrective: a long view. The wicked seem to flourish for a moment; the righteous inherit forever.

Three commands open the psalm. Fret not. Envy not. Trust. These are the daily disciplines of the believer facing apparent injustice. Fretting is the spiritual equivalent of constantly checking a wound. Envying the wicked is letting their apparent success poison your contentment. Trust is the alternative, letting God hold what you cannot control.

The reason for not fretting is the long view: the wicked are like grass. They look prosperous in the morning. By evening, they wither. Compared with eternity, the success of the wicked is brief. The temptation is to compare time spans incorrectly, to weigh ten years of someone’s worldly success against eternity and conclude that they are winning. But the comparison is wrong. They will fade. The righteous endure.

Verse 4 is one of the most quoted in the Psalter: “Delight yourself in the LORD, and he will give you the desires of your heart.” This is sometimes misread as a transaction, delight in God and you will get what you want. But the deeper meaning is transformative: delight in the LORD, and your desires themselves will be reshaped. What you want will become what he wants. The desires of your heart, properly aligned with God, will indeed be granted, because they will be the right desires.

The image of “rolling your way onto the LORD” in verse 5 is wonderful. You roll your burden onto someone else, and you are free of it. The Christian life involves daily rolling, daily handing over to God what you cannot carry yourself.

Verse 11 anticipates Jesus’ Beatitude: “The meek shall inherit the land.” Jesus quoted this exact verse in Matthew 5:5. The meek, those who do not assert their rights, who do not fret about injustice, who do not envy the wicked, they get the inheritance in the end. The world thinks meekness is weakness. The Bible says meekness is the strongest posture, because it trusts the One who holds the future.

And the psalm gives us a striking image of God: “The LORD laughs at the wicked, for he sees that his day is coming.” God is not anxious about injustice. He laughs. Not in cruelty, but in confidence. He knows the end. He knows when the wicked will fall. He knows when his people will be vindicated. We can rest in that knowledge.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph has just been thrown into prison for refusing to sin. His brothers, who sold him into slavery, are eating well at home. Potiphar's wife, who lied about him, sleeps in her bed. Joseph sleeps in chains. Psalm 37 is the song Joseph could have prayed. Do not fret. Trust the LORD. The wicked are like grass. The meek inherit. This is the wisdom that sustained Joseph in his unjust suffering, and it is the wisdom that sustains believers still.

STEP 6

Application

Today, examine where you are fretting. What injustice in your life are you turning over and over? What success of someone else are you watching with envy? Bring it before God. Then practice the three commands: Fret not. Envy not. Trust. And practice the discipline of verse 4, delight yourself in the LORD. Not as a strategy to get what you want, but as a means of becoming someone whose wants are right.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what makes you fret or envy, and lay it before him.
- Ask him to reshape your desires by delight in him.
- Pray for patience to wait for him and not for your own way.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 53 · WEEK 8

Psalm 37:23-40

The steps of a man are established by the LORD

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 37:23-40 slowly, twice. This is the second half of the great wisdom psalm. The themes continue: the patient confidence of the righteous, the certain end of the wicked. As you read, listen for the personal note David sounds, his own life experience speaking.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The second half of Psalm 37 continues the meditation on the long view. The psalmist now adds his personal testimony: "I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken." David has lived through enough to know how God's economy works. The patient eventually receive. The wicked eventually fall. The promise of the meek inheriting the land continues to anchor the psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 23: "The steps of a man are established by the LORD, when he delights in his way." God orders the path of his people.
2. Verse 24: "Though he fall, he shall not be cast headlong, for the LORD upholds his hand." Falls happen, but recovery follows.
3. Verse 25 is David's personal testimony: "I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken."
4. Verses 27-29: Turn from evil, do good, dwell forever. The righteous have the long inheritance.
5. Verses 30-31 describe the speech and heart of the righteous: "the law of his God is in his heart; his steps do not slip."

6. Verse 34: “Wait for the LORD and keep his way, and he will exalt you to inherit the land.”
7. Verses 35-36: The wicked man flourished like a green tree, but when the psalmist looked again, he was gone.
8. Verses 37-38: “Mark the blameless… for there is a future for the man of peace.”
9. The psalm closes: “The salvation of the righteous is from the LORD; he is their stronghold in the time of trouble.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

The second half of Psalm 37 deepens what the first half established. Trust the LORD. Wait for him. The wicked will pass; the righteous will inherit. But now David adds personal witness. He has lived a long life. He has seen things. And what he has seen confirms what the psalm has been saying.

Verse 23 is profound. “The steps of a man are established by the LORD, when he delights in his way.” For the believer who delights in God’s way, every step is established. Not random. Not accidental. Even the falls that happen are caught by the LORD’s hand. Verse 24: “though he fall, he shall not be cast headlong.” This is one of the great pastoral truths of the psalm. Christians fall. We sin. We make mistakes. We stumble. But we are not cast headlong, because the LORD upholds our hand. The fall does not become a free fall, because the same LORD who established our steps catches us when we stumble.

Verse 25 is David’s testimony. “I have been young, and now am old, yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken or his children begging for bread.” This is not a promise of material prosperity, believers do face poverty in this fallen world. But it is a testimony about God’s faithfulness across a lifetime. David has watched. He has paid attention. The righteous get cared for, sometimes in ways that seem miraculous, but always somehow. God does not forsake those who fear him.

The image of the wicked in verses 35-36 is striking. “I have seen a wicked, ruthless man, spreading himself like a green laurel tree. But he passed away, and behold, he was no more; though I sought him, he could not be found.” David is describing what he has watched happen. The villain who seemed unstoppable simply…disappeared. There came a day when his glory was gone, and even the search for his memory turned up nothing. Time is on the side of the righteous.

The psalm closes with a beautiful summary. “The salvation of the righteous is from the LORD; he is their stronghold in the time of trouble. The LORD helps them and delivers them; he delivers them from the wicked and saves them, because they take refuge in him.” This is

the architecture of Christian confidence. Not our righteousness, but his salvation. Not our strength, but his stronghold. Not our deliverance, but his hand. We take refuge in him. He does the saving.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 37 is the wisdom psalm that fits Joseph's situation, fits David's situation, and fits the believer's situation in every age. Yesterday Joseph was thrown into prison for refusing to sin. Today, Psalm 37 reminds us that the righteous are not forsaken. The LORD establishes our steps. We will yet be vindicated.

STEP 6

Application

Today, mark the blameless. Verse 37 says, "Mark the blameless and behold the upright, for there is a future for the man of peace." Take some time today to think about someone you know who has lived a quiet life of faithfulness. Maybe a parent or grandparent. Maybe a pastor or teacher. Maybe a friend who has walked with God through real hardship. Mark them. Tell them what you have seen. And ask God to make you one of those who, in old age, can say: I have been young, and now am old, and I have not seen the righteous forsaken.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to order your steps today, one by one.
- Thank him that when you fall he upholds your hand.
- Ask him for a long faithfulness that becomes its own testimony.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 54 · WEEK 8

Genesis 40:1-41:57

The cupbearer and baker; Pharaoh's dreams; Joseph exalted

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 77 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 40:1-41:57. Joseph in prison interprets dreams for two of Pharaoh's officials. Two years later, Pharaoh has dreams of his own, and Joseph is finally remembered. The seventeen-year-old slave is now a thirty-year-old vizier of Egypt.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joseph has been in prison for some time. Two of Pharaoh's officials, the chief cupbearer and the chief baker, are imprisoned with him, and each has a strange dream. Joseph interprets both. The cupbearer is restored to his position; the baker is executed. Joseph asks the cupbearer to remember him, but he forgets, for two years. Then Pharaoh has dreams that none of his wise men can interpret, and the cupbearer finally remembers Joseph. Joseph stands before Pharaoh, interprets the dreams, and is elevated to second in command over all of Egypt.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Joseph's first words about dream interpretation: "Do not interpretations belong to God? Please tell them to me" (40:8).
2. Joseph correctly interprets both dreams, but the cupbearer forgets him.
3. Two years pass before Pharaoh's dream. Joseph is in his early thirties when he finally stands before Pharaoh.
4. Pharaoh's dreams: seven fat cows eaten by seven gaunt cows; seven good ears of grain eaten by seven blighted ears.
5. Joseph attributes everything to God: "It is not in me; God will give Pharaoh a favorable answer" (41:16).

6. He interprets the dream, seven years of plenty followed by seven years of famine, and recommends a plan.
7. Pharaoh promotes Joseph: "Can we find a man like this, in whom is the Spirit of God?"
8. Joseph receives Pharaoh's signet ring, fine linen, a gold chain, and the second chariot. He is renamed Zaphenath-Paneah.
9. Joseph marries Asenath. They have two sons: Manasseh ("God has made me forget all my hardship") and Ephraim ("God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction").
10. The seven years of plenty come and go; the famine arrives; people from every land come to Egypt to buy grain.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 40 and 41 are the turning point in Joseph's story and the moment when the long providence of God becomes visible. For thirteen years, Joseph has been moving steadily downward, from favored son, to slave, to favored servant, to wrongly accused, to forgotten prisoner. In a single day, he ascends from prison to the second highest position in the empire.

The chapters teach us something essential about God's timing. The cupbearer could have remembered Joseph immediately, and Joseph might have been freed. But God's plan required Joseph in prison for two more years. Why? Because Pharaoh did not yet need a dream interpreter. The famine had not yet come. The whole reason God positioned Joseph in Pharaoh's court was so that he could be there to manage the seven years of plenty and the seven years of famine. If Joseph had been released too early, he would have been just another freed slave. God's timing requires the suffering.

Joseph's interpretive principle is striking. "Do not interpretations belong to God?" he says in chapter 40. And to Pharaoh in chapter 41: "It is not in me; God will give Pharaoh a favorable answer." Joseph has spent thirteen years in adversity. He has every reason to be bitter, to claim credit, to assert himself. Instead, he points to God at every turn. Notice that he is doing this before a pagan king who could grant him freedom or send him back to prison. Joseph is not editing his theology for a different audience. He says the same thing to Pharaoh that he said to the cupbearer in prison.

Pharaoh's response is remarkable. "Can we find a man like this, in whom is the Spirit of God?" An Egyptian king recognizes the Spirit of God in a Hebrew slave. The same Spirit who will fill the prophets and ultimately fill Christ is at work in Joseph, and even Pharaoh can see it. The text is making a point: when God is genuinely with someone, even unbelievers can recognize it.

Joseph's elevation is total. He receives Pharaoh's signet ring (delegated authority), fine linen and a gold chain (royal insignia), and the second chariot (proximity to power). He is renamed, a sign of his new identity. He marries an Egyptian woman, Asenath. He has two sons whose names carry deep theological meaning. Manasseh, "God has made me forget all my hardship." Joseph is naming his first son after the way God has worked in him. The bitter years are not erased, but they are now bearable. Ephraim, "God has made me fruitful in the land of my affliction." Joseph is acknowledging that the place of his suffering became the place of his blessing. Egypt was the place of his slavery, his false accusation, his forgotten years. Now Egypt is the place of his fruitfulness. The land of affliction has become the soil of his calling.

Then the seven years of plenty come and go, and the famine arrives. The text says people from "all the earth" came to Egypt to buy grain. The stage is being set for the family of Jacob to make the journey south. Joseph is in place. The famine is the means. God is preparing to bring his promise, that Israel would sojourn in a land that was not theirs, into history.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph's elevation is one of the great divine reversals in the Old Testament. Sold for twenty shekels of silver, he becomes the second most powerful man in Egypt. The reversal points forward to Christ, who, sold for thirty pieces of silver, became the King of kings. And the seven years of famine that will draw Joseph's family to Egypt is the beginning of the four hundred years of sojourning that God predicted to Abram in Genesis 15.

STEP 6

Application

Two truths to take with you. First, your timing is not God's timing. The two years Joseph waited in prison felt unnecessary to him; they were essential to what God was doing. The waiting season you are in may feel pointless. It is not. God is using the time. Second, the place of your affliction may become the place of your fruitfulness. Egypt was Joseph's land of suffering before it became the land of his calling. Whatever hard season you are in, physical, emotional, vocational, relational, God can make it the soil of unexpected fruit. Pray today that he will make you, like Joseph, fruitful in the land of your affliction.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God about a season of waiting that feels pointless, and ask him to use it.

Ask him to make you fruitful where you are afflicted.

Ask for grace to give him credit in your conversations and work.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 55 · WEEK 8

Genesis 42:1-43:34

Brothers in Egypt; Benjamin brought; Joseph's emotion

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 72 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 42:1-43:34. The famine has reached Canaan. Jacob sends his sons to Egypt to buy grain. They stand before Joseph without recognizing him. Joseph plays a long, careful game, testing his brothers, seeing if they have changed.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The famine in Canaan grows severe. Jacob is forced to send ten of his sons, all but Benjamin, the youngest, down to Egypt to buy grain. They stand before the Egyptian vizier without recognizing him, but he recognizes them. Joseph could reveal himself immediately. He does not. Instead, he engineers a careful series of tests to discover whether his brothers have changed. He accuses them of being spies. He demands they bring Benjamin. He keeps Simeon as a hostage. He plants their money back in their sacks. The brothers return home in fear. Then, when the food runs out, they must return, this time with Benjamin.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 42:6, Joseph's brothers bow down before him, fulfilling his dreams from twenty years earlier.
2. Joseph recognizes them but pretends not to. He speaks to them through an interpreter.
3. He accuses them of being spies, threatens them, and tests them. He is harsh on the surface, weeping privately.
4. He keeps Simeon as a hostage and sends the rest home to bring Benjamin.
5. On the journey home, they discover their money returned in their sacks. Their consciences begin to stir: "What is this that God has done to us?"

6. When they reach Jacob, he refuses to send Benjamin. “You would bring down my gray hairs with sorrow to Sheol.”
7. The famine grows worse. Eventually, Judah persuades Jacob: “I will be a pledge of his safety. From my hand you shall require him.”
8. The brothers return with double money and gifts. Joseph receives them, sees Benjamin, and is overcome.
9. Joseph hosts a feast for them. Benjamin’s portion is five times the others, a deliberate test of jealousy. The brothers pass.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two chapters are an emotional crescendo. Joseph, twenty years after being sold into slavery, finally faces his brothers. He could destroy them. He has the power. They are at his mercy. But Joseph is not interested in revenge. He wants to know if they have changed.

The testing is masterful. Joseph speaks roughly. He accuses them of being spies. He demands they bring their youngest brother. He keeps one as hostage. He plants their money back in their sacks. Every move is designed to put them in a tight place where their true character will surface. And the brothers begin to crack. As soon as the trouble starts, they whisper among themselves: “In truth we are guilty concerning our brother, in that we saw the distress of his soul, when he begged us and we did not listen. That is why this distress has come upon us.” Twenty years of buried guilt rises up. They have not forgotten Joseph. They have just been carrying him as a hidden weight.

Joseph hears them. The text says: “They did not know that Joseph understood them, for there was an interpreter between them. Then he turned away from them and wept.” This is one of the most moving scenes in Genesis. Joseph hears the confession he has been waiting twenty years to hear, and he weeps. Not because they are suffering. Because they are owning what they did. The transformation has begun.

The journey home and the painful conversation with Jacob is excruciating. Jacob cannot bear to lose another son of Rachel. Benjamin is all he has left of his beloved wife. He refuses to send him. The famine forces the issue, but it is Judah who finally breaks through. “I will be a pledge of his safety. From my hand you shall require him. If I do not bring him back to you and set him before you, then let me bear the blame forever.”

This is a transformation. Judah is the brother who once said, “Let us sell him to the Ishmaelites.” Now he is offering himself as security for the youngest. The man who proposed selling Joseph is now pledging his own freedom for Benjamin. This is exactly what Joseph has been testing for. Has Judah changed? The answer is yes.

When they return to Egypt with Benjamin, Joseph cannot keep his composure. He sees his brother, his only full brother, for the first time in over twenty years. He has to leave the room to weep. He composes himself, returns, and hosts a banquet. He seats them in birth order, to their astonishment. He gives Benjamin five times the portion of the others, a deliberate test. Twenty years ago, special favor for the youngest son led to murderous jealousy. How will they react now?

They eat and drink with him. There is no jealousy. The brothers have changed.

STEP 5

Connection

Joseph's dreams from Genesis 37 are now being fulfilled in real time, his brothers bowing before him. But the deeper purpose is the transformation of the brothers themselves. The man who once proposed selling Joseph is now offering himself for Benjamin. This is the seed of Judah becoming the kingly tribe, the tribe from which David and ultimately Christ will come.

STEP 6

Application

Sometimes love requires the long test. Joseph could have revealed himself immediately. He could have showered his brothers with gifts and forgiveness on day one. He did not. He took them through a process. The process was not cruelty, it was love directed at transformation. Sometimes the people we love most need our slowest, most patient confrontation, not our immediate forgiveness. Forgiveness is given. Trust is rebuilt. The two are not the same thing. Today, ask God for wisdom about a relationship where you have been asked to receive someone back. Forgive freely. But do not skip the work of rebuilding trust.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for the wisdom to forgive freely and to rebuild trust slowly where it has been broken.

Tell him about someone you long to see reconciled, and pray for them.

Ask him to give you a heart like Joseph's, full of love and ready for tears.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 8

“The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed.”

GENESIS 39:23

DAY 56 · WEEK 8

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. The week you have completed followed Joseph from his lowest point, sold into slavery, falsely accused, forgotten in prison, to his elevation as second over Egypt. Take time today to consider how God was with Joseph at every stage of his descent.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD was with Joseph, and whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed."

GENESIS 39:23

REST

Meditation

Genesis 39:23 is the refrain of the Joseph story. The phrase "The LORD was with Joseph" appears multiple times, when he is sold as a slave, when he is in Potiphar's house, when he is in prison, when he stands before Pharaoh. Wherever he is, the LORD is with him.

This is the gospel's promise restated. Joseph's circumstances ranged from privileged son to abused slave to wrongly accused prisoner to ruler of Egypt. In every condition, the LORD was with him. The presence of God was not contingent on Joseph's success. It was the source of his eventual success, but it was equally present in his lowest moments.

Say the verse to yourself, particularly the second half, "whatever he did, the LORD made it succeed." This is not a promise that everything you attempt will work out. It is a promise that God's purposes through you cannot fail. Joseph's "success" included thirteen years of

suffering. The LORD's success and our preferred outcomes are not always the same thing, but they are always good, and they are always sure.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

The week began with Esau's genealogy and then plunged into the Joseph story, the dreams, the brothers' hatred, the selling into slavery. You read the strange Judah-Tamar story alongside Joseph's integrity in Potiphar's house. You worshiped through both halves of Psalm 37, learning the wisdom of patience while the wicked seem to prosper. You watched Joseph rise from prison to second in command over all of Egypt. And the week ended with his brothers standing before him without recognizing him, bowing down, just as Joseph's childhood dreams had foretold.

The week is about hidden providence. Joseph could not see what God was doing. The brothers could not see what God was undoing. But the LORD was with Joseph at every step, through betrayal, false accusation, forgotten years in prison, and the same LORD was preparing the moment of reversal.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Where in your life right now does it feel like the LORD is not "making it succeed"? Joseph's experience suggests that God's presence is not always evident through circumstances. The thirteen years between Joseph's sale and his elevation included times when even he must have wondered if God had forgotten him. What season are you in? How does Joseph's story help you wait?

How does Joseph point you to Christ? Joseph was the beloved son, sold for silver, falsely accused, imprisoned with criminals, elevated to a throne, and used by God to save the very brothers who had betrayed him. Every detail prefigures Jesus. Where do you see Christ most clearly in the Joseph story? And how does seeing Joseph's reversal deepen your hope in Christ's resurrection?

Where do you need to choose integrity in your own "Potiphar's house"? Joseph said no to a powerful person's advances when no one would have known. He chose the harder right over the easier wrong. Is there a place in your life today where integrity will cost you something? What would it look like to choose it anyway, trusting that the LORD is with you?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for being with Joseph in the pit, in prison, and on the throne, and for being with you in every season.

Ask him to make you a person of integrity in the place you are right now.

Rest in his presence this Sabbath, in success and in failure.

DAY 57 · WEEK 9

Genesis 44:1-45:28

Judah's plea; Joseph revealed, grace to those who betrayed

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 55 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 44:1-45:28. The climax of the Joseph narrative. Joseph stages one final test, Benjamin will be arrested for theft. Judah's response is one of the great speeches in the Old Testament. And then Joseph reveals himself, and the long, agonizing reunion finally happens.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Joseph has tested his brothers thoroughly. He has one final test to administer. He plants his silver cup in Benjamin's sack and sends them home. His steward overtakes them, accuses them of theft, and announces that Benjamin must remain in Egypt as a slave. This is the moment of truth. Will the brothers abandon Benjamin as they abandoned Joseph twenty years ago? Or has something changed in them? Judah's response is one of the most moving speeches in the Bible. And after hearing it, Joseph can no longer hold back.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Joseph plants his silver cup in Benjamin's sack, a final test of how the brothers will respond when Benjamin is in trouble.
2. When the steward catches up to them, all the brothers tear their clothes (a sign of deep grief) and return together.
3. Judah steps forward. His speech (44:18-34) is one of the longest individual speeches in Genesis.
4. Judah recounts the family history honestly. He emphasizes how Jacob loves Benjamin and how his loss would kill the old man.

5. Verse 33: Judah offers himself in Benjamin's place. "Let your servant remain instead of the boy as a servant to my lord, and let the boy go back with his brothers."
6. Joseph cannot hold back. He sends all the Egyptians out of the room and weeps so loudly that the Egyptians outside hear him.
7. His self-revelation: "I am Joseph! Is my father still alive?" The brothers are speechless with dread.
8. Verse 5: "Do not be distressed or angry with yourselves... for God sent me before you to preserve life."
9. Joseph repeats the theme: "It was not you who sent me here, but God" (verse 8).
10. He tells them to bring Jacob and the whole family to Egypt, they will live in Goshen, near him.
11. The chapter ends with Jacob hearing the news and refusing to believe it, then finally believing: "It is enough; Joseph my son is still alive."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis 44 and 45 are the moral and theological climax of the Joseph story. Everything has been building toward Judah's speech and Joseph's revelation. After this, the rest of Genesis is denouement.

The final test is engineered with perfect insight. Joseph plants his cup in Benjamin's sack. When the brothers are caught, they have a choice. They could blame Benjamin, leave him behind, and walk away. After all, only Benjamin is accused. The rest of them are free to go. This is exactly what they did to Joseph twenty years ago. They handed him over and walked away. The cup test is asking: will they do it again?

Their response is the first proof. Verse 13: "They tore their clothes." All of them. Together. This is communal grief. They cannot bear to lose another brother. They return to the city together, not separately.

Then Judah steps forward. His speech is one of the longest sustained speeches in Genesis, and it is masterful. He recounts the family history honestly. He explains how Jacob has already lost one son (Joseph, presumed dead), and how losing Benjamin would kill the old man. The speech is full of his father's words, Judah quotes Jacob repeatedly, as if he has been listening, as if he finally understands what Benjamin means to his father.

And then comes the moment. Verse 33: "Now therefore, please let your servant remain instead of the boy as a servant to my lord, and let the boy go back with his brothers." Judah offers himself. The brother who once said, "Let us sell him to the Ishmaelites," is now offering to be the slave instead. Twenty years ago, Judah benefited from selling a brother. Now Judah is willing to suffer to save a brother. This is what transformation looks like. The kingly tribe is being formed in this moment. The tribe of David, the tribe of Christ, formed by a Judah who finally learns to lay down his life for his brother.

Joseph cannot hold back. He has been keeping up the appearance of harsh Egyptian official for chapters now, weeping in secret rooms. He cannot any longer. He sends all the Egyptians out, this revelation is family business, and he weeps so loudly that the Egyptians outside the room hear him. And then the words: "I am Joseph. Is my father still alive?"

The brothers are paralyzed with terror. The man they sold has become the man with power over their lives. He could have them all killed in an instant. But Joseph's next words are the heart of the gospel of Genesis. "Do not be distressed or angry with yourselves because you sold me here, for God sent me before you to preserve life." Notice the theology. Their sin was real. God's purpose was real. Both are true. Joseph does not minimize what they did. He acknowledges it. But he sees that, behind their sin, God was working, moving the pieces, positioning Joseph in Egypt, so that when the famine came, life could be preserved. The same event was both wickedness (on the brothers' part) and providence (on God's part). Acts 4:28 will say exactly the same thing about the crucifixion of Christ.

Joseph repeats the point three times in this short speech. "God sent me before you to preserve life." "It was not you who sent me here, but God." "He has made me a father to Pharaoh and lord of all his house." This is not naive optimism. This is hard-won theology. Joseph has spent thirteen years in slavery and prison. He has every right to be bitter. He chooses instead to see the hand of God. And by choosing that, he releases his brothers from their guilt and saves the family.

STEP 5

Connection

Judah's offer of himself for Benjamin is the moment that transforms the kingly tribe. From this man and this moment will come David, and from David will come Christ, the true substitute who takes the place of his brothers. And Joseph's interpretation of his suffering, "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good" (which will be stated explicitly in chapter 50), anticipates Romans 8:28: "all things work together for good for those who love God."

STEP 6

Application

Look at your story with Joseph's eyes. The wrongs done to you were real. The sin against you was real. But behind every betrayal, every loss, every closed door, God was working, moving the pieces, positioning you for what came next. This is not denial of pain. Joseph wept. But it is faith in providence. Today, name one painful chapter of your life that, in retrospect, you can begin to see God's hand in. Thank him for it. And ask him to give you Joseph's eyes for the chapters you cannot yet read.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Name a wound that was real, and tell God about it without softening it.
- Ask him to give you Joseph's eyes to see how he has used it, or may yet use it.
- Ask him for a heart willing to lay down its life for others, like Judah's.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 58 · WEEK 9

Genesis 46:1-47:31

Jacob to Egypt; Israel settled in Goshen

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 66 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 46:1-47:31. Jacob and the whole family, seventy people, make the long journey down to Egypt. They are settled in Goshen. Jacob meets Pharaoh. The years pass, and Jacob prepares for his death.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The famine continues. Jacob, now an old man, packs up the entire family and heads to Egypt. On the way, God appears to him at Beersheba and confirms the move: “Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make you into a great nation.” Joseph rides out to meet his father after twenty-two years. The family is settled in the region of Goshen, the best of the land. Jacob is presented to Pharaoh. The years pass. Jacob, near death, makes Joseph swear to bury him in Canaan, not Egypt.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jacob stops to offer sacrifices at Beersheba. He is honoring the place where his father Isaac had also encountered God.
2. God speaks to Jacob in night visions, calling him “Jacob, Jacob”, affectionate repetition.
3. Verse 46:3: “Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make you into a great nation.” This fulfills Genesis 15:13.
4. The list of seventy persons (46:8-27) is the foundation of Israel. Seventy is a number of completeness.
5. Joseph rides up in his chariot to meet Jacob. They weep together. Twenty-two years of separation.

6. Jacob is presented to Pharaoh. He blesses Pharaoh, the lesser blessing the greater? Or the patriarch blessing the king?
7. Jacob's life, "few and evil have been the days of the years of my life", is candidly described as hard.
8. The famine grows severe. The Egyptians sell their flocks, then their land, then themselves to Pharaoh in exchange for food.
9. Israel settles in Goshen, prospers, and multiplies (verse 47:27).
10. Jacob, near death, makes Joseph swear with the same oath Abraham used, to bury him in the cave of Machpelah.

STEP 4

Interpretation

These two chapters cover the final settling of the patriarchal family in Egypt. The descent into Egypt that began with Joseph as a slave now welcomes the whole family as honored guests. The four-hundred-year sojourning that God predicted to Abram in Genesis 15:13 has officially begun.

Notice the careful way the move is framed. Jacob does not just rush off to Egypt. He stops at Beersheba, the place his father Isaac worshiped, and offers sacrifices. He pauses to seek God's blessing on the journey. And God meets him. In a night vision, God speaks: "I am God, the God of your father. Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt, for there I will make you into a great nation. I myself will go down with you to Egypt, and I will also bring you up again." This is one of the most important promises in the patriarchal narratives. God is going down to Egypt with them. The God of Canaan is not bound to Canaan. He travels with his people. And he commits to bring them back. The descent is real, but it is not abandonment.

The list of the seventy who came to Egypt is the foundation of Israel. The biblical writers will refer to this number repeatedly. Seventy elders will accompany Moses to Sinai. Seventy disciples will be sent out by Jesus. The number marks the people of God, small, complete, gathered.

The reunion between Joseph and Jacob is brief but powerful. "Joseph presented himself to him and fell on his neck and wept on his neck a good while. Israel said to Joseph, "Now let me die, since I have seen your face and know that you are still alive."" Twenty-two years of grief and waiting end in a single embrace.

Jacob is presented to Pharaoh. The exchange is striking. Jacob "blesses Pharaoh" both at the beginning and end of the encounter. Hebrews 7:7 says, "It is beyond dispute that the inferior is blessed by the superior." The aged patriarch blessing the king of Egypt is a quiet but

powerful statement of who really represents the God of heaven. Jacob's life is described candidly: "Few and evil have been the days of the years of my life, and they have not attained to the days of the years of the life of my fathers." Jacob has not had an easy life. He acknowledges it. But he stands before Pharaoh as a man of God.

The famine policy section (47:13-26) is one that bothers many modern readers. Joseph collects all the money from Egypt, then all the livestock, then all the land, in exchange for food. By the end, the Egyptians have sold themselves into Pharaoh's service. Joseph is implementing what is essentially a transition from a free society to a centralized monarchy. The text describes this without moral comment. The full implications will become visible only later, when a new pharaoh, one who "did not know Joseph", uses this centralized power to enslave Jacob's descendants.

The chapter ends with Jacob, near death, calling Joseph and making him swear an oath. The patriarchs are passing the covenant. Jacob will not be buried in Egypt. He will be buried in the cave of Machpelah, with Abraham and Sarah, with Isaac and Rebekah, with Leah. The covenant family does not lose its grip on the promised land even in the years of Egyptian residence. They will be sojourners, but their bones will go home.

STEP 5

Connection

The descent into Egypt is the literal fulfillment of Genesis 15:13. God told Abram his offspring would sojourn in a foreign land for four hundred years. The journey down begins here. And God's promise to Jacob, "I will bring you up again", is the seed of the Exodus, the great act of redemption that will define Israel's identity.

STEP 6

Application

Two truths to take with you. First, when God calls you somewhere difficult, he goes with you. He told Jacob, "I myself will go down with you to Egypt." He still goes with his people. Whatever Egypt you find yourself in, a hard season, a difficult place, an unwelcome calling, God does not stay behind. He goes. Second, your story is part of a longer story. The descent into Egypt would have looked like a tragedy to anyone watching. From God's vantage point, it was the means by which a family became a nation. Your present descent may be the means by which God is making something larger than you can yet see.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that he goes with you into every hard place.

Ask him to make you willing to leave what is familiar when he calls.

Thank him that he brings his people up again after every descent.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 59 · WEEK 9

Genesis 48:1-50:26

Jacob's blessings; Judah's primacy; Joseph's death

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Genesis 48:1-50:26. The final three chapters of Genesis. Jacob blesses Joseph's sons and then blesses all twelve of his own sons in a prophetic poem. He dies and is buried in Canaan. Joseph forgives his brothers a final time. Genesis ends with his bones in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the return to the promised land.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We have come to the end of Genesis. Jacob, near death, calls Joseph to him and blesses Joseph's two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, crossing his hands so that the younger receives the greater blessing. Then in chapter 49 he summons all twelve sons and prophesies their futures. The blessing on Judah is particularly significant, a scepter will not depart from him until the one to whom it belongs comes. Jacob dies. Joseph and the brothers travel to Canaan to bury him. Joseph reassures the brothers one final time and dies at 110, his bones embalmed and placed in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the day they will be carried back to the promised land.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jacob adopts Joseph's two sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, as his own, they become two of the twelve tribes.
2. Jacob crosses his hands, blessing the younger (Ephraim) over the older (Manasseh), the pattern of election repeats.
3. Genesis 49 is the blessing of the twelve sons, one of the most important prophetic poems in the Old Testament.

4. Reuben loses his birthright for defiling his father's bed. Simeon and Levi are cursed for their violence.
5. Judah receives the great blessing: "The scepter shall not depart from Judah… until tribute comes to him; and to him shall be the obedience of the peoples."
6. This is one of the earliest Messianic prophecies, the one to whom the scepter belongs is the coming Christ.
7. Joseph receives a double portion through his two sons. He is called "a fruitful bough by a spring."
8. Jacob dies. The Egyptians mourn him for seventy days, extraordinary honor.
9. Joseph and his brothers carry Jacob's body to Canaan and bury him in the cave of Machpelah.
10. After Jacob's death, the brothers fear retribution. Joseph weeps: "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good."
11. Joseph dies at 110. His last words: "God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here."

STEP 4

Interpretation

Genesis ends in a way that anticipates everything still to come. Jacob blesses his sons, and the future of the twelve tribes is sketched out in advance. Joseph forgives his brothers in the most theologically loaded sentence in the book. And the patriarchal era closes with Joseph's bones in a coffin, waiting for the Exodus.

Jacob's blessing of Ephraim and Manasseh is the latest example of the pattern that has run throughout Genesis. The younger is preferred over the older. Isaac over Ishmael. Jacob over Esau. Now Ephraim over Manasseh. When Joseph tries to redirect his father's hands to favor the older son, Jacob refuses. "I know, my son, I know." The pattern is not accidental. God's grace consistently overturns natural expectations. He does not save by birth order, by merit, by social standing. He saves by sovereign choice.

Genesis 49 is one of the most important prophetic chapters in the Old Testament. Jacob, dying, calls his sons together and tells them what will happen "in days to come." The text is dense and poetic. Reuben loses his right of firstborn for his earlier sin with Bilhah. Simeon and Levi are cursed for their violent revenge against Shechem, they will be scattered in Israel (which Levi will become, as the priestly tribe scattered among the others, and Simeon, which will eventually be absorbed into Judah).

And then comes the great Judah blessing. "Judah, your brothers shall praise you... The scepter shall not depart from Judah, nor the ruler's staff from between his feet, until tribute comes to him; and to him shall be the obedience of the peoples." This is one of the earliest and clearest Messianic prophecies in the Bible. From Judah will come the line of kings. From Judah will come David. And from the line of David will come the one to whom the scepter ultimately belongs, Jesus Christ, the Lion of the tribe of Judah (Revelation 5:5). The wine and milk imagery in the next verse suggests a kingdom of abundance. The blessing on Judah is the seed of the entire kingdom theology of the Old Testament.

Joseph's blessing is also notable. He receives a double portion through his two sons. He is described as a fruitful bough whose branches run over the wall. The blessings that came to him "are mighty beyond the blessings of my parents, up to the bounties of the everlasting hills." Joseph receives more, in some ways, than his fathers. The suffering son becomes the most blessed.

Then Jacob dies. The Egyptians mourn him for seventy days. Joseph and his brothers travel to Canaan with an enormous procession to bury Jacob in the cave of Machpelah. The covenant family does not stay in Egypt at death. They go home to the land of promise, even just to be buried there.

When they return, the brothers are afraid. They suspect Joseph has only been kind to them because Jacob was alive. Now that Jacob is dead, will Joseph take revenge? They send a message claiming Jacob's deathbed wish was that Joseph forgive them. Whether the message is true or fabricated is unclear. But Joseph weeps. And then he speaks one of the most theologically important sentences in the Old Testament. Genesis 50:20: "As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today."

This sentence is the gospel of Genesis in miniature. Human evil is real. Divine purpose is real. Both are true at once. The same event, the brothers selling Joseph into slavery, was both wickedness (on their part) and providence (on God's part). The same will be true at the cross. The crucifixion of Christ was the most evil act in human history. It was also the most loving act of God in human history. The brothers crucified Christ. God meant it for good.

Genesis closes with Joseph's death. He is 110. He gathers his brothers around him and says, "God will surely visit you, and you shall carry up my bones from here." He is embalmed and placed in a coffin in Egypt. The coffin is the last image of Genesis. Not the promised land. Not victory. A coffin in Egypt. But Joseph has the eyes of faith. He knows God will visit. He knows the bones will be carried up. And four hundred years later, when the Exodus comes, Moses will indeed take Joseph's bones with him out of Egypt (Exodus 13:19). The faith of one man at the end of Genesis becomes the assurance of an entire nation's redemption.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis ends in suspense. The covenant family is in Egypt. The promise of the land is unfulfilled. Joseph's bones lie in a coffin. But the prophecy of Judah, "the scepter shall not depart", points all the way to Christ. The promise to Abraham is still operative. The God of the patriarchs has gone down to Egypt with them, and he will bring them up again. Everything that follows in the Bible flows from this moment.

STEP 6

Application

Make Genesis 50:20 your own theology. You will face evil in this life. Sins will be committed against you. Tragedies will strike. People will betray you. The Christian does not pretend these are good. They are evil. But the Christian also believes that God is at work behind every evil, not causing it, but ordering history so that even the worst events serve his redemptive purposes. The cross is the proof. The worst day in human history became the day of salvation. If God can do that with Calvary, he can do it with your story too.

And take heart from Joseph's coffin. He died in faith. He never saw the promised land. But he saw it by faith, and he trusted that God would visit his people. Some of God's promises will not be fulfilled in your lifetime. Some answers to your prayers will come after you are gone. The Christian does not need to see everything completed before death. We die in faith, trusting the God who keeps his word across generations.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Give God the wrongs and losses you carry, and ask him to use them for the good of others.

Ask him to make you someone who weeps but forgives, suffers but trusts.

Pray that you would hold to his promise to the end of your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

“You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive.”

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 60 · WEEK 9

Psalm 47

God has gone up with a shout, the universal king of all nations

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 9 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 47 twice. This is a short, exuberant psalm of God's kingship over all the nations. It is the perfect note on which to close the patriarchal narratives. The promise to Abram, that all nations would be blessed, finds its first hymn-form celebration here.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 47 is a short, festive psalm celebrating God's reign over all the nations. It was probably sung at one of Israel's major festivals, perhaps connected with the ascension of the king or the procession of the ark to the temple. It is one of the most joyful psalms in the Psalter and one of the most explicitly universal. The God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob is also the King of all the earth. The promise to Abram that "in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed" is the theological foundation of this psalm.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a universal call: "Clap your hands, all peoples! Shout to God with loud songs of joy!"
2. Verse 2: "For the LORD, the Most High, is to be feared, a great king over all the earth." Universal kingship.
3. Verse 3: "He subdued peoples under us, and nations under our feet." Israel's victories are framed as God's reign.
4. Verse 4: "He chose our heritage for us, the pride of Jacob whom he loves." The patriarchal covenant celebrated.
5. Verse 5: "God has gone up with a shout, the LORD with the sound of a trumpet!" Image of divine ascension.

6. Verses 6-7 call repeatedly for praise: “Sing praises to God, sing praises!”
7. Verse 8: “God reigns over the nations; God sits on his holy throne.”
8. The psalm ends: “The princes of the peoples gather as the people of the God of Abraham. For the shields of the earth belong to God; he is highly exalted!”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 47 is one of the most joyful psalms in the entire Psalter, and it is precisely the right psalm to close out the patriarchal narratives. The whole point of God’s choice of Abraham was that, through one family, all nations would be blessed. Psalm 47 sings that promise as a present reality. The nations clap their hands. The peoples shout. God is king over all the earth.

The opening call is universal: “Clap your hands, all peoples!” Not just Israel. Not just the covenant family. All peoples. The psalmist is summoning every nation on earth to worship the God of Abraham. This is the Abrahamic Covenant set to music. The blessing that began with one man is meant for everyone.

Verse 2 declares the foundation: “The LORD, the Most High, is to be feared, a great king over all the earth.” Notice the divine name, El Elyon, God Most High. This is the very name used by Melchizedek when he blessed Abraham in Genesis 14. The same God who blessed Abraham is the great king over all the earth. The God who chose one family is also the God who reigns over every nation.

Verse 4 makes the patriarchal connection explicit. “He chose our heritage for us, the pride of Jacob whom he loves.” God’s choice of Jacob, the choice that has dominated the chapters we have been reading, is celebrated as his ongoing love for Israel. This is not contradiction to the universal scope. It is the means by which the universal blessing arrives. God chose one family in order to bless all families.

The image of verse 5 is striking. “God has gone up with a shout, the LORD with the sound of a trumpet!” This is the language of triumphal ascension, perhaps originally describing the ark being carried up to the temple, but in Christian reading, it has long been seen as pointing to Christ’s ascension. The same image will be used in Ephesians 4:8 about the risen Christ. The king has ascended. He reigns from above.

Then comes the repeated command: sing praises. Five times in two verses. The psalm cannot contain its joy. The God who reigns deserves praise from every voice.

Verse 8 is the theological climax: “God reigns over the nations; God sits on his holy throne.” This is one of the clearest statements in the Old Testament that God’s kingship is not local. He is not Israel’s tribal deity. He reigns over the nations. He sits on his holy throne. Every other throne is provisional. His alone is eternal.

And the closing verse: “The princes of the peoples gather as the people of the God of Abraham.” This is the climax of the whole patriarchal story. The princes of every people, the rulers of every nation, gather as members of the family of Abraham. The promise has come full circle. Through one family, blessing has come to all families. The God of Abraham is now the God of every nation that worships him.

STEP 5

Connection

We close Unit 3 with this psalm because it is the patriarchal promise in song. The covenant began with one man and one family. By Psalm 47, it has expanded, at least in vision, to embrace all the nations of the earth. Pentecost will be its first historical fulfillment. The new heavens and new earth, where “a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages” stand before the throne, will be its final fulfillment.

STEP 6

Application

Clap your hands. Shout to God with songs of joy. The God who chose Abraham is your God. The God who reigns over all the earth is your King. There is no nation outside his reach, no people group beyond his redemptive purposes, no enemy too strong for his throne. This should produce joy, not just gratitude, but exuberant celebration. The world’s news will tell you many other things. The truth is that God reigns. Let that truth restore your joy today.

And pray for the nations. The princes of the peoples gather as the people of the God of Abraham. Your prayer for missions, for unreached peoples, for nations that do not yet know the gospel, your prayer is in alignment with this psalm. Pray bigger than your own life today.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God as king over all the nations, in your own words.
- Ask him to restore your joy in his reign.

Pray for the gospel to reach people in a nation you rarely think about.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 61 · WEEK 9

Psalm 66:1-7

Shout for joy to God, all the earth

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 66:1-7 slowly, twice. This is the opening of one of the Psalter's great worship psalms. The first seven verses summon all the earth to praise God and recall his works of deliverance, particularly the Exodus. It is the right psalm to anticipate the next unit of our plan.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 66 is a great national psalm of thanksgiving. The first half (which we read today) calls all the earth to worship God for his mighty works. The second half (which the plan does not include here) gets more personal, recounting how the worshiper has tested God in suffering and been delivered. Today we read the public, corporate opening of the psalm. It looks back at the Exodus, which we are about to read in detail, and summons every nation to praise the God who made it happen.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Verse 1: "Shout for joy to God, all the earth." Universal call to worship.
2. Verses 2-4: God's name and glory are to be celebrated by all peoples, even God's enemies will cringe before him.
3. Verse 5: "Come and see what God has done: he is awesome in his deeds toward the children of man."
4. Verse 6 specifically recalls the Exodus: "He turned the sea into dry land; they passed through the river on foot."
5. The crossing of the Red Sea and the Jordan are both alluded to, God's redemptive acts in history.

6 Verse 7: “Who rules by his might forever, whose eyes keep watch on the nations, let not the rebellious exalt themselves.”

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 66:1-7 is a call to worship grounded in God’s mighty acts of redemption. It is, in a sense, the opening anthem of the gospel of God’s deliverance.

The psalm opens by summoning the whole earth. “Shout for joy to God, all the earth.” Notice how universal the call is. This is not a private psalm for Israelites alone. It is a summons to every people, every nation, every voice on earth. Worship is meant to be global. God’s glory is not Israel’s private property; it is a flame that every nation should burn around.

Verses 2-4 connect God’s name with his glory. “Sing the glory of his name; give to him glorious praise!” The name of God is the focus of worship. Throughout the patriarchal narratives, we have seen God revealing his name in different forms, El Shaddai to Abraham, El Olam at Beersheba, the LORD at the burning bush (which we will read soon). The whole patriarchal story has been a gradual unveiling of who God is, and the appropriate response is worship of his name.

But then verse 3 has an arresting note: “Through the greatness of your power your enemies come cringing to you.” Worship is not just from the willing. Even God’s enemies eventually cringe before him. This is not the language of universalism (every soul finally saved) but of universal recognition (every knee will bow, whether in glad worship or fearful submission). The same will be expressed in Philippians 2 about Christ, “every knee should bow… and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.”

Verse 5 invites the reader to look at history. “Come and see what God has done.” This is the basic posture of biblical faith. Look at what God has done. The patriarchal story is a record of what God has done. The Exodus is what God has done. The cross is what God has done. Faith is not blind. It looks at the deeds of God in history and worships in response.

And then verse 6 specifically recalls the Exodus: “He turned the sea into dry land; they passed through the river on foot. There did we rejoice in him.” The crossing of the Red Sea, and possibly also the crossing of the Jordan into the promised land, is mentioned as the supreme example of God’s redemptive power. This is the great event that defined Israel as a nation, and it is also the great picture that the New Testament will use for baptism, for salvation, for passing through death into life.

Verse 7 closes the section with a sober reminder. “Who rules by his might forever, whose eyes keep watch on the nations, let not the rebellious exalt themselves.” God reigns. He watches. The rebellious may make a lot of noise, but they should not exalt themselves. God’s

eyes are on the nations. Nothing escapes his rule. Whatever it looks like from the ground, the King is on his throne.

STEP 5

Connection

We are about to enter the Exodus narrative in the next unit. Psalm 66 is a fitting preview. It calls every nation to praise the God who turned the sea into dry land. The redemption of Israel from Egypt was not just a national story, it was a public demonstration of God's power that the whole world should learn from and worship in response to. The God of the Exodus is the God who still saves his people from every form of bondage.

STEP 6

Application

Take the psalmist's first command: shout for joy. The Christian life is meant to be full of joy in worship. Not somber acknowledgment, not dutiful gratitude, shouting joy. If your worship has gone quiet over time, let this psalm be a prophetic correction. The God who delivered Israel from Egypt is the same God who delivered you from sin and death. He deserves more than a polite thank-you.

And take the second command: come and see. Look at what God has done. Not just in Scripture, but in your own life. Make a habit of reviewing the redemptive acts of God on your behalf. The healings, the answered prayers, the prevented disasters, the spiritual breakthroughs. Come and see. Then sing.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Come and see what God has done, and tell him what you see in his work, from creation to the cross to your own life.

Ask him to restore your joy in worship.

Pray that the nations would join in praising him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 9

“You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive.”

GENESIS 50:20

DAY 62 · WEEK 9

Review and Reflection

Unit 3 review, The Abrahamic Covenant

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."
>
> GENESIS 15:6

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 3.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Genesis 15:6 is the foundational verse of the doctrine of justification by faith. It is the verse Paul will quote in Romans 4 and Galatians 3 as the proof that justification has always been by faith, never by works of the law. Abraham believed God, and God counted it to him as righteousness. The transaction was simple, and it is the same transaction by which every Christian is justified today.

Say this verse aloud several times. Notice three things. First, Abraham believed. He did not earn, achieve, perform, or negotiate. He believed. Second, God counted it. The accounting is divine. God moves something from heaven's ledger into Abraham's account. Third, what God counted was righteousness. Not credit toward future righteousness. Not the possibility of righteousness. Righteousness itself. Abraham, who had lied about his wife, who had taken Hagar instead of waiting, who would lie again, Abraham was reckoned righteous because he believed.

This is your verse too if you are in Christ. You have believed. God has counted Christ's righteousness to you. You are reckoned righteous before the throne. Not because of your performance. Because you believed.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 3 you have traveled through Genesis 12 to 50, the entire patriarchal narrative. The unit began with the call of Abram, the great narrowing of God's redemptive plan to one man and one family through whom all nations would be blessed. You followed Abraham through his call, his journey, his lies, his rescue of Lot, his meeting with Melchizedek, the formal cutting of the covenant in Genesis 15, the institution of circumcision, the long-awaited birth of Isaac, and the binding of Isaac on Mount Moriah.

Along the way, the plan paused for the doctrine of Covenant Theology, naming the structure that runs throughout the Bible. Five covenants, one unfolding story, all fulfilled in Christ.

The unit then continued through Isaac's quieter life, Jacob's deception and flight, his vision of the ladder at Bethel, his twenty years with Laban, the formation of the twelve tribes through Leah, Rachel, and the maidservants, his wrestling with God at Peniel, his reconciliation with Esau, and the renewal of the covenant at Bethel.

The Joseph narrative dominated the second half of the unit. Joseph sold by his brothers, falsely accused by Potiphar's wife, forgotten in prison, finally elevated to second in command over Egypt, reuniting with his brothers, and forgiving them with the great theological summary: "You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good."

The unit closed with Jacob's death, his blessing of Judah (the scepter that would not depart), and Joseph's bones in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the Exodus to come.

The Psalms accompanied the journey: Psalm 105 in two parts, summarizing the patriarchal story in song; Psalm 121 and the Psalms of Ascent, teaching us to walk by faith; Psalm 37, the wisdom of patience under apparent injustice; Psalm 47 and Psalm 66, the universal kingship of God over all nations.

The big theological lessons of this unit are these: God's covenant operates by election and grace, not by birth order or merit. Justification has always been by faith. God's promises take time, sometimes decades, and they are fulfilled in his way, not ours. God's providence works behind every event of human history, including the wickedness of others. And the line of Judah, the kingly tribe, runs all the way from Genesis 49 to Christ, the Lion of Judah, in whom every patriarchal promise finds its yes.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What are the three elements of God's promise to Abraham, and how does each find fulfillment in Christ?

Read Genesis 12:1-3 again. The three elements are land, offspring (a great nation), and universal blessing (all families of the earth blessed). Each finds fulfillment in Christ: the land is fulfilled in the new heavens and new earth, the offspring is fulfilled in Christ himself (Galatians 3:16, "to Abraham and to his offspring... who is Christ"), and the universal blessing is fulfilled in the gospel going to every nation. Write a few sentences in your own words about how the gospel today fulfills each element of God's promise to Abraham.

What does the covenant cutting of Genesis 15 reveal about the nature of God's grace?

Look back at Genesis 15. In the ancient Near East, both parties to a covenant walked between the cut pieces, pledging by self-curse to keep the covenant. But in Genesis 15, only God walks between the pieces. The covenant is one-sided. God binds himself to keep what he has promised, regardless of Abram's faithfulness. This is grace in its purest form, God taking on himself the entire weight of the covenant. Centuries later, Christ on the cross was torn like the animals in Genesis 15, bearing the curse so that God's people could be blessed. Sit with this. What does it mean for your assurance that God's covenant with you depends on his faithfulness, not yours?

How does the story of Joseph function as a type of Christ?

Walk through Joseph's life. He was the beloved son of his father (Genesis 37:3). He was hated and rejected by his brothers (37:4). He was sold for silver (37:28). He was wrongly accused and condemned (39:14-20). He was raised from the prison and given a name above every name in Egypt (41:39-43). He saved his brothers, including those who had sold him, by his elevation. He forgave them and provided for them. Every detail anticipates Christ. Take a moment to consider: in what specific ways did Joseph's suffering and exaltation point forward to Jesus' death and resurrection?

What does it mean that Abraham "believed God and it was counted to him as righteousness"?

Genesis 15:6, the most important Old Testament verse for understanding the New Testament's doctrine of salvation. Three things are happening here. First, Abraham believed, faith is the means of justification, not works. Second, God counted, the accounting is divine, not earned. Third, what was counted was righteousness, Abraham was reckoned righteous before God on the basis of faith alone, not on the basis of his moral performance (which had already failed and would fail again). Paul will use this verse in Romans 4 to prove that justification has always been by faith. If you have believed in Christ, this is true of you too. Pray through this. Thank God that you are reckoned righteous, not because of who you are, but because of who Christ is.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for keeping his promise to Abraham when no one else could.
- Thank him that you are a child of Abraham through faith in Christ.
- Ask him to keep the unit verse in front of you.

DAY 63 · WEEK 9

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 3 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. Yesterday closed Unit 3 with the review of the entire patriarchal narrative. Today closes the week with rest. The book of Genesis is now behind you. Take time today to feel the weight of what you have read, and to anticipate the Exodus to come.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive."

GENESIS 50:20

REST

Meditation

Genesis 50:20 is the theological climax of the entire patriarchal narrative, and of the entire book of Genesis. It is two sentences in one.

"You meant evil against me", the brothers' sin was real. Joseph does not minimize what they did. There is no false forgiveness here, no pretending nothing happened.

"But God meant it for good", behind their wickedness, God was working. Moving the pieces. Positioning Joseph in Egypt so that, when the famine came, many lives could be preserved. The same event was both wicked (on the brothers' part) and providential (on God's). Both are true at once.

This will eventually be said about the cross. The crucifixion of Christ was the most evil act in human history. It was also the most loving act of God in history. The same event. Both sentences true.

Carry this verse through your week. When you face injustice, remember it. When you mourn a wrong done to you, remember it. The God who turned Joseph's pit into a throne can do the same with your story.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week closed the patriarchal era and the book of Genesis. You read Judah's plea for Benjamin, the brother who once proposed selling Joseph now offering himself for the youngest. You watched Joseph reveal himself, weep, and forgive. You traveled with the family of Jacob down to Egypt and settled in Goshen. You read Jacob's prophetic blessings on his twelve sons, including the famous promise that the scepter would not depart from Judah. You watched Joseph die, his bones placed in a coffin in Egypt, awaiting the Exodus four hundred years later. You worshiped with Psalm 47 (God's reign over the nations) and the opening of Psalm 66 (all the earth called to praise). And yesterday you completed the Unit 3 review, anchored on Genesis 15:6, justification by faith.

Genesis is over. The patriarchal family is in Egypt. The four-hundred-year sojourning has begun. And the Lion of Judah stands over everything still to come.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Looking back at Genesis as a whole, where did your understanding of God deepen most? You have walked through 50 chapters in about 9 weeks. The book introduced God as Creator, Judge, Covenant-maker, Provider, the God of the patriarchs. Which face of God did you most need to see in this season of your life? Why?

How does Genesis 50:20 prepare you to read about the cross? When you reach the Gospels later in this plan, you will encounter the most evil act ever committed, and the most loving act God ever performed, in the same event. Joseph's words to his brothers are the theological key. Sit with this. How does the resurrection prove that what humans meant for evil, God meant for good?

What patriarchal failure most resembles your own? Genesis is candid about the failures of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph's brothers. Lies. Favoritism. Manipulation. Betrayal. Drift. Where do you see your own story in theirs? And where do you see God's grace operating despite their (and your) failures?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what you have seen of his hand through the book of Genesis.

Thank him that what others meant for evil he meant for good, supremely at the cross.

Ask him to give you Joseph's eyes for what lies ahead.